

# Jazz



## INTRODUCTION

### BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF TONI MORRISON

Toni Morrison grew up in Northeast Ohio, where her ostensibly integrated small town was in fact deeply inflected by racial prejudice and violence. After attending college at Howard University (America's oldest historically Black university), Morrison got an M.A. from Cornell, where she studied modernist writers like William Faulkner and Virginia Woolf. Post-college, Morrison spent several years teaching at universities and working in publishing at Random House while writing her first novel, *The Bluest Eye*. *The Bluest Eye* received minimal attention upon its initial release (though it has since been recognized as a classic). Morrison then followed her debut up with *Sula*, *Song of Solomon*, and *Beloved* (1987), the novel that made her a literary celebrity and a household name. In 1993, one year after she published *Jazz*, Morrison was awarded the Nobel Prize for Literature. In the latter part of her life, Morrison continued to write, spend time with her sons Harold and Slade, and teach at Princeton University, before she passed away in 2019 at the age of 88. She is considered a literary icon and an important voice on issues of racial and gender justice.

### HISTORICAL CONTEXT

*Jazz* takes place in the epicenter of the Harlem Renaissance, an explosion of Black music, theater, art, literature, and theory in the 1920s and early 1930s. This period is sometimes known as the Jazz Age, as it was the moment in which jazz—which had its roots in the New Orleans Black community—gained wider popularity across the United States. But while the characters of *Jazz* exist in this flourishing cultural milieu, they are also haunted by darker events in American history. In 1914, just 11 years before the novel begins, the U.S. had fought in the devastatingly violent World War I. Upon returning home, many Black veterans found they were still not accorded respect despite the service they had done for their country. Then, in 1917, the East St. Louis massacre broke out, one of the deadliest episodes of anti-Black white violence in the nation's history. The massacre spurred many protests, including the NAACP Silent Protest Parade that Alice Manfred watches in the novel, though it was largely ignored by the mainstream media.

### RELATED LITERARY WORKS

Morrison had long been interested in modernist classics like William Faulkner's *Absalom, Absalom* and Virginia Woolf's *To*

*The Lighthouse*. But *Jazz*, first inspired by an image Morrison saw in James Van Der Zee's *The Harlem Book of the Dead*, specifically drew on several works from the Harlem Renaissance era of art and music it was depicting. Morrison was likely influenced thematically by Zora Neale Hurston's novel *Their Eyes Were Watching God*, and she may have taken some of the rhythmic, almost poetic prose of *Jazz* from works like Sterling A. Brown's *Southern Road*. Perhaps most importantly, *Jazz* is also intimately related to two of Morrison's other novels, *Beloved* and *Paradise*. Taken together, Morrison intended the three to form a trilogy about love and African-American history (with *Beloved* focusing on the years right after the Civil War, *Jazz* focusing on the Jazz Age of the 1920s, and *Paradise* taking place in the mid-1970s).

### KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** *Jazz*
- **When Written:** Early 1990s
- **Where Written:** Princeton, New Jersey and Hudson Valley, New York
- **When Published:** 1992
- **Literary Period:** Contemporary
- **Genre:** Novel
- **Setting:** Harlem, New York City
- **Climax:** Joe Trace tracks his young lover Dorcas to a party, where he shoots and kills her.
- **Antagonist:** Dorcas
- **Point of View:** First Person

### EXTRA CREDIT

**Picking Favorites.** Morrison's most widely-read books are *Beloved* and *Song of Solomon*, but Morrison frequently told interviewers that *Jazz* was the novel she was most proud of. *Jazz*, which was among the works cited when Morrison won the Nobel Prize, is also considered the author's most difficult text, largely because of its complex form (meant to mimic the structure of jazz itself).

**Intertextual Interest.** Morrison herself has compared Wild, one of the characters in *Jazz*, to the titular character of her previous novel *Beloved*. But some recent literary scholars have gone even further in linking the two novels, suggesting that *Jazz*'s Joe Trace is himself actually *Beloved*'s son—and that *Beloved* and *Wild* are not just similar but one and the same.



## PLOT SUMMARY

It's winter 1926 in Harlem, and an unnamed narrator is gossiping about her neighbors, a married couple named Joe and Violet Trace. Joe has been having an affair with a much younger woman named Dorcas, until, in a moment of jealousy, he shoots and kills her. A few weeks later, Violet shows up—uninvited—to Dorcas' funeral, and tries to stab the dead girl in the face. After the funeral, Violet returns home, where she lets all of her **birds** out of their cages. Every night, she and Joe sneak out of bed to look at the framed photo of Dorcas on their mantel. The narrator predicts that soon, another murder will occur.

The narrator jumps back to before the murder. Violet, a hairdresser, had been behaving strangely. One time, she sat down, inexplicably, in the middle of the street; another time, she held someone else's baby for so long that people accused her of kidnapping. Joe, unaware of this strange behavior, was busy renting a room from his neighbor Malvonne. Joe and Dorcas would meet often in this room to talk and have sex. Joe, who sells Cleopatra beauty products, would use this time to shower Dorcas with presents.

Now, the story rewinds to 1917, when a group of Black protestors march up Fifth Avenue to oppose the horrific racial violence of the East St. Louis massacre. Alice Manfred has lost her sister and brother-in-law in the massacre, making her responsible for her orphaned young niece, Dorcas. Alice is terrified by the constant racism she experiences, even in the relatively prosperous Black enclave of Harlem; she hopes to protect her niece with strict rules, banning the makeup and jazz that she thinks makes people do "unwise disorderly things." Privately, though, Alice admires jazz's "appetite" and "complicated anger."

Dorcas, having seen her childhood home set on fire with her mother inside of it, ignores her aunt's rules, wanting to be "bold." Dorcas craves sex above all, and by the time she is a teenager, she is often sneaking out to parties with her best friend Felice. At one of these house parties, Dorcas sees two handsome brothers dancing in the center of the living room. Dorcas is excited to dance with the brothers, but they wrinkle their nose at her.

Back in 1926, Violet keeps trying to talk to Alice Manfred. Alice initially refuses to let Violet in, but eventually her curiosity gets the better of her, and the two women strike up a strange friendship. Alice makes tea and patches Violet's clothes, and Violet talks about her complicated feelings towards Joe. Alice keeps quiet about her own painful experience, many years ago, with an unfaithful husband.

Violet thinks back to her youth in Vesper County, Virginia. When Violet was a little girl, all of her family's belongings (including their home) were seized, prompting her mother Rose

Dear to lose her grip on sanity. The only way Violet survived was because her grandmother True Belle returned from Baltimore to care for the children. Four years after True Belle arrived, Rose Dear threw herself down a well.

Hoping to escape the painful memories of her mother, Violet went to the nearby town of Palestine, where she met Joe Trace. From the first moment she met Joe, Violet wanted this man to be her husband. Eventually, Joe and Violet headed to New York City, falling in love with the big buildings and bustling energy. They had agreed on not wanting children, but as she got older, Violet started falling asleep with a doll in her arms, a sign to Joe that maybe she wanted a baby after all.

Back in the present, winter turns into spring, but Joe still does nothing except cry over Dorcas. The narrator muses that Joe seems nice, but in reality, he is lecherous and resentful; she thinks his affair with Dorcas was inevitable, and that Joe is a broken **record** "bound to the track."

Joe takes over the narrative, describing his childhood in Vesper County. Joe never knew his parents, though he found a surrogate family and a best friend named Victory. As children, Joe and Victory worked with the best hunter in their town, a tracker named Henry Lestory (whom everyone called Hunter's Hunter). In 1906, Joe moved to New York with Violet, and eventually they found their way to Harlem. Their life there was mostly peaceful, though in 1917, Joe was randomly attacked by a vicious group of white people. A few years later, Joe fell for Dorcas, cherishing her acne and trying to overlook her interest in younger men. Dorcas felt like the first real decision Joe had ever made.

The narrator now imagines herself into True Belle's life. True Belle worked for a white woman named Vera Louise. As a teenager, Vera got pregnant with an enslaved Black man (later revealed to be Henry Lestory); her family kicked her out, and Vera went to live in Baltimore, forcing True Belle to come with her. Vera had her baby, naming him Golden Gray because of his golden hair color and bronze skin. In Golden's youth, Vera and True Belle spent all their time doting on the young child.

After years of believing he was white, Golden eventually learned the truth about his father and set out to meet Henry in the flesh. While on the way, Golden stumbled upon an injured pregnant woman. At first, he hesitated to help the woman (largely because she is Black), but Golden finally decided to bring her back to Henry's small cabin, where he covered her with a **green dress**. Henry came home, and Golden explained who he is. The woman, known only as Wild, then went into labor.

As a child, Hunter hinted to Joe that Wild, now a haunting legend for the townspeople, is his true mother. Joe searched for Wild several times, even after white people burn his village to the ground, but Wild never identifies herself as his mother. Joe then recalls the day he hunted Dorcas down, holding a gun

not because he meant to harm her but because that is how Hunter had taught him to “track” people down.

The narrative shifts perspective once again, as Dorcas describes dancing at a party with her arrogant new lover Acton. Hazily, Dorcas recalls Joe’s arrival at the party. Before she understands what is happening, Dorcas is on the floor, mumbling something to Felice. Music plays in the background as Dorcas, having been shot, loses consciousness and dies.

Now, Felice tells her story. She was raised by her grandmother while her parents worked far away; her friendship with Dorcas was the most exciting part of her life. Several months after the funeral, while trying to retrieve a ring Dorcas had borrowed, Felice ends up at the Trace household. To her surprise, Felice likes Violet and Joe, and she respects how tender they are to each other. The strange trio starts spending time together, making dinners and dancing. Violet gets another bird, and she brings it to the roof to hear jazz.

The narrator is frustrated with herself for being so wrong about Joe and Violet. She had thought “that the past was an abused record with no choice but to repeat itself,” but now she realizes that people are “original, complicated, changeable—human.” The narrator watches Joe and Violet visit locations around New York City together, and she wishes she had left her house more often. Maybe then, she too could have this kind of “public love.”

utterly confident whenever she speaks the word “me.”

**Joe Trace** – Joe Trace is a salesman for Cleopatra beauty products; he is also Violet’s husband, Dorcas’ lover, and (probably) Wild’s son. Joe’s lack of a relationship with his birth mother Wild shapes him profoundly, and both the narrator and Violet come to realize that Joe’s fixation on Dorcas is part of his attempt to regain some of the intimacy he lost as a child (a loss often symbolized by the **green dress** Golden Gray gave to Wild). This confusion between the past and the present extends to Joe’s murder of Dorcas, which he links to his youth spent hunting with the skilled tracker known as Hunter’s Hunter. Joe’s conflicting motivations also make it difficult for others to understand him. Alice Manfred laments that Joe has a reputation as a respectful neighbor, but that he still preys on young Dorcas; conversely, the narrator dismisses Joe as a womanizer, then realizes he is a more decent, “original” person than she initially gave him credit for. Felice, getting to know Joe several months after he murders her best friend, can only muse that “he likes women,” not just flirting with them but respecting them “without that.” And most importantly, Felice notes, even after years of distance and infidelity between Joe and Violet, she “really believe[s] he likes his wife.” In other words, despite the harm Joe causes, by the end of the novel his relationship with Violet contains the very tenderness and care he has spent his life searching for.

**The Narrator** – The unnamed narrator is a resident of Harlem who watches Joe, Violet, and Dorcas through her window and imagines for herself any details of their histories and relationships that she does not have firsthand access to. The narrator is initially confident in her predictions about the neighbors she observes, asserting that Joe and Violet are doomed to harm each other over and over again (like “an abused **record** with no choice but to repeat itself”). But as the narrator digs deeper, investigating Joe’s relationship with Wild and the story of Golden Gray’s birth, she begins to doubt her earlier confidence: “I have been careless and stupid,” she vents, “and it infuriates me to discover (again) how unreliable I am.” By the end of the novel, the narrator finds her expectations completely upended, and she has to admit that people are more “complicated” and “changeable” than she initially believed. She also gains new admiration for Joe and Violet’s late-in-life tenderness, and she envies Wild, with her acceptance of chaos and her bright **green dress**. The narrator is a mysterious figure in the novel, and her lack of a clear identity is a source of fascination for scholars and for Morrison herself.

**Alice Manfred** – Alice Manfred is a seamstress and Dorcas’s maternal aunt. When Dorcas’s parents are both killed in the anti-Black attacks of the East St. Louis massacre, Alice steps in to take care of the newly orphaned little girl. Alice’s loss—combined with her frequent firsthand experiences of racism in New York City—makes her fearful, and she imposes strict rules on Dorcas, instructing her niece to avoid risqué



## CHARACTERS

### MAJOR CHARACTERS

**Violet Trace** – Violet is a hairdresser in Harlem. She is Joe Trace’s wife, Rose Dear’s daughter, and True Belle’s granddaughter; over the course of the narrative, she also becomes a close friend to Alice Manfred. When the novel’s unnamed narrator first introduces Violet (“Violent,” as her neighbors call her), she appears to be dangerous, unhinged and unloving: Violet shows up to Dorcas’ funeral just to stab the already-dead girl, considers kidnapping a baby, and won’t say a word either to her husband or to her **parrot**. But as Violet reflects on her painful childhood—which includes her mother’s suicide—and forges a maternal relationship with Dorcas’ friend Felice, she is able to gain new understanding and peace with herself. At first dissociating from her most violent actions (by referring to the version of herself who commits them as “*that* Violet”), Violet eventually integrates the conflicting parts of her personality, proudly declaring that “*that* Violet was me!” And as she talks with Alice and Felice, Violet is able to work through the complicated feelings she holds about motherhood, finding surrogate children in her community even though she can no longer have biological ones. Perhaps most essentially, Violet patches up her relationship with Joe, building an intimacy with him that allows her to “make” and “remake” herself, and to feel

clothing and jazz (which Alice calls “lowdown music”). After Dorcas’ death, Alice initially loathes both Joe and Violet. But when Violet continues to show up at Alice’s door, the two women strike up a friendship, allowing both of them to process their experiences of infidelity. Alice eventually extends a great deal of care to Violet, making her tea, mending her tattered clothes, and encouraging Violet to forgive Joe if she feels like she can.

**Dorcas** – Dorcas is Joe’s lover, Alice Manfred’s niece, and Felice’s best friend. After losing both her parents in the violence of the East St. Louis massacre, Dorcas becomes “bold,” breaking her aunt’s strict rules, going out to clubs, and chasing after young men. Though she is wounded by some early romantic rejection, Dorcas responds positively to Joe’s advances, and the two begin sleeping together in a room Joe rents from Malvonne. But Dorcas, frustrated by Joe’s doting nature, chases after the more negligent Acton, prompting Joe to track her down in a jealous haze. Dorcas’s youthful passion (she describes going to parties as being at “war”) clouds her judgment, and she does not seem to fully comprehend the severity of her injuries. As Dorcas dies, the only thing she can take solace in is the jazz music she loves so much. “Listen,” she thinks, losing consciousness, “I don’t know who is that woman singing but I know the words by heart.” Dorcas is viewed by both Felice and Violet as selfish, though Joe insists she was “softer” than either of those women give her credit for.

**Felice** – Felice is Dorcas’s best friend. Felice’s father and mother live mostly in Tuxedo, so Felice is raised by her relatively conservative grandmother. Though Felice is impressed by Dorcas’s boldness—and grateful for the excitement her friend brings to her life—she resents Dorcas’ focus on men, particularly her relationships with Joe and Acton. It is especially frustrating to Felice that Dorcas does not work harder to stay alive after Joe shoots her, a fact that Felice sees as a devaluation of the duo’s near-lifelong friendship. After Dorcas’s death, Felice strikes up a surprising relationship with Joe and Violet, bringing them **records** and sharing dinner with them. This trio’s dynamic is a source of great intrigue to the narrator, who initially predicts that these friendships will end in murder. But to the narrator’s surprise, Felice, Joe, and Violet all help each other heal from their various losses, proving just how “original, complicated” and “changeable” human beings can be.

**True Belle** – True Belle is Rose Dear’s mother and Violet’s grandmother. After years of being enslaved by Vera Louise’s family, True Belle returns home to provide for Rose Dear and her children. True Belle, with her crafty solutions and willingness to laugh even in the face of tragedy, is a hero to Violet; she teaches Violet that “laughter is [...] more complicated, more serious than tears.” As True Belle helps put Violet’s family back together in the wake of Rose Dear’s mental collapse, she tells stories of Vera Louise’s son Golden Gray. The narrator believes that True Belle’s memories of washing Golden

Gray’s soft, blonde curls are likely what catalyzed Violet’s decision to become a hairdresser in adulthood.

**Golden Gray** – Golden Gray is the son of Vera Louise and Henry Lestory, though his closest relationship as a child was really with True Belle. Because of his blonde hair, his bronze skin, and the stories his mother told him, Golden grew up believing he was white. Once he learns that his father is Black, Golden struggles with his own deeply internalized racism, using slurs to refer to Henry and dismissing even his beloved True Belle as “nothing” because of her dark skin tone. When Golden sees Wild injured on the road, he decides to take her back to Henry’s cabin, more to prove a point than because of any sense of moral obligation. For decades, Golden’s soft curls and inconsistent behavior remains an object of fascination for both Violet and the narrator; the narrator in particular struggles to decide whether she empathizes with Golden’s “hurt” or resents him as a “hypocrite.”

**The Woman/Wild** – Wild is first introduced as the frightened pregnant woman Golden Gray spots on the side of the road. With help from Henry Lestory, Golden, and Honor, Wild is able to give birth to her child (likely Joe), but she soon disappears back into the woods. Most of the people in Vienna think Wild is just an urban legend, but Henry remembers her kind laugh and her friendship with Golden. Later in his life, Joe tries to make contact with Wild, but she will never acknowledge him as her son; he comes to associate her only with a quiet patch of hibiscus, and with the potent, conflicting scents of honey and excrement. Both Joe and the narrator often symbolically associate Wild with a **green dress** that Golden found for her.

**Henry Lestory/Hunter’s Hunter** – Henry Lestory (known to most Vienna residents as Hunter’s Hunter) is Golden Gray’s father and Joe’s mentor. Henry is the most respected animal tracker in the area, and he is used to being accorded respect by locals like Joe, Honor, and Victory. He has little tolerance, therefore, for Golden’s racialized arrogance, insisting that “a son ain’t what a woman say. A son is what a man do.” Henry helps Wild through her difficult pregnancy, and he later hints to Joe that Wild is Joe’s real mother—even as he tries to manage Joe’s expectations around this fact. Towards the end of the narrative, when Joe begins tracking Dorcas down, he is often reminded of Hunter’s advice about what is and is not meant to be “prey.”

**Vera Louise** – Vera Louise is a prosperous white woman, the daughter of the plantation owners who enslave both True Belle and Henry Lestory. As a young woman, Vera has an affair with Henry, which leads her family to exile her. Vera Louise moves to Baltimore with True Belle in tow, separating True Belle from her own family. Together, the two women raise Golden Gray, the blonde son that results from Vera’s relationship with Henry. At the end of the Civil War, Vera Louise begins paying True Belle, but she holds her wages “in trust,” a sign that Vera Louise is more like her white supremacist parents than she would care



to admit.

**Rose Dear** – Rose Dear is Violet’s mother and True Belle’s daughter. After her husband (Violet’s father) disappears and her belongings are repossessed, Rose Dear struggles to hold onto her sanity. Eventually, Rose Dear commits suicide by throwing herself down a well. Violet’s memories of her mother’s pain make her hesitant to ever have children of her own.

**Violet’s Father** – Violet’s father is a member of the Readjuster Party, which aimed to increase voting rights for Black citizens across Virginia. He is frequently absent from Violet’s childhood home, returning home only once a decade (often with lavish presents in tow). During one of Violet’s father’s long absences, his wife Rose Dear dies by suicide—a tragedy that is underscored when Violet’s father comes back just 10 days later with an embroidered pillow for her. The narrator suspects that Violet’s father’s political involvement led to his family’s belongings being repossessed.

**Malvonne** – Malvonne is Joe and Violet’s gossip neighbor. She is very concerned with her nephew Sweetness, and with the stories she reads in discarded letters. Malvonne rents Joe her room to use with Dorcas, though she makes it clear (repeatedly) that she does not approve of this affair. Malvonne is often used as comic relief throughout the novel.

**Acton** – Acton is the arrogant young man (the “rooster,” as Joe puts it) that Dorcas leaves Joe for. Whereas Joe is patient with Dorcas, Acton is often critical of her, refusing her public displays of affection and making disparaging remarks about her weight. Felice notes that Dorcas chases after Acton in much the same way that Joe chases after Dorcas. Acton is present at the party where Dorcas is shot, and they are dancing together when Joe arrives (though Acton seems inappropriately nonchalant about his lover’s serious injuries).

**Victory Williams** – Victory is Joe’s best friend from childhood. After Victory’s parents took the abandoned baby Joe in, Victory—also an infant—becomes almost a surrogate brother to Joe. Joe reflects that Victory is the first (and for a long time, the only) person in the world that he can confide in entirely. The two boys do almost everything together: Victory hunts alongside Henry Lestory, just like Joe, and both boys move to the neighboring town of Palestine when Vienna is burned down.

**Gistan** – Gistan is one of Joe’s best friends in New York City. Along with Stuck, Gistan often plays cards with Joe late into the night. Every so often, Gistan and Stuck allude to Violet’s strange behavior, but unlike with his childhood friend Victory, Joe does not feel like he can be totally transparent with them.

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**Felice’s Father** – Felice’s father works in Tuxedo, visiting Felice with his wife (Felice’s mother) every few weeks. Early in the novel, Felice’s father is glued to his newspapers, carefully tracking incidents of white violence against Black communities. By the end of the narrative, Felice’s father has found a more fulfilling job working as a Pullman porter.

## MINOR CHARACTERS

**Honor** – Honor is a teenager living in Vienna, Virginia. He is mentored by Henry Lestory, and he is proud of this relationship with the village’s foremost hunter. Honor is the first person Golden Gray meets upon arriving to Virginia, and he helps Wild through her difficult labor.

**Felice’s Grandmother** – Felice’s grandmother is the main person responsible for raising Felice. She is depicted as a relatively devoted family member, though she does not approve of Felice’s relationship with Dorcas. After Joe shoots and kills Dorcas, Felice’s grandmother speculates that Dorcas “brought it on herself.”

**Felice’s Mother** – Felice’s mother works in Tuxedo, and she only gets leave to return home to her daughter once a month. Though Felice’s mother is normally a very rule-abiding person, Felice once sees her steal an opal ring from Tiffany’s jewelry store.



## THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don’t have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



### ROMANTIC LOVE

Most of the characters in *Jazz* struggle with unrequited love. Violet’s husband Joe Trace betrays her by beginning an affair with a much-younger woman named Dorcas; Dorcas lusts after an arrogant, disinterested man named Acton; Dorcas’ aunt Alice Manfred still longs for her husband, who has been dead for decades. Even the animals in the novel seem heartbroken—Violet’s **parrot**, for example, squawks “I love you” all day long, only to hear nothing from its owners in return. Importantly, in almost every case, the characters’ romantic yearning is underscored by their desire for missing family members: Joe, Violet, and Dorcas have all lost their parents either through death or abandonment, and Alice has lost her siblings. And in each instance, the characters find the marriages and affairs they enter into to be unsatisfying attempts at recreating the

unconditional love they craved as children, as their romances are passionate but devoid of comfort and intimacy.

At first, then, the novel seems to suggest that this unhappiness is an endless cycle, and that unreciprocated familial love in childhood begets dissatisfaction and heartbreak in adult romantic relationships. But as Violet and Joe sort through their past and present pain, they realize that the gap between romance and family does not need to feel so large. Instead, over the course of the novel, Violet and Joe work to recreate with each other the domestic bonds neither of them had in their youth, sharing meals and dances and (eventually) the happiest and most fraught memories of their childhood. Rather than positing family trauma as an inevitable source of romantic disappointment, therefore, *Jazz* depicts romance as a place where a new kind of familial love can be chosen, created, and constantly renewed.



### JAZZ, IMPROVISATION, AND REINVENTION

In the introduction to her 1992 novel *Jazz*, novelist Toni Morrison writes that she wanted her book to capture “the essence of the so-called Jazz Age”—what she defines as “improvisation, originality, change.” In the narrative, as married couple Joe and Violet Trace navigate life in 1920s Harlem, they are struck again and again by the prevalence of jazz music. Young people stay up late dancing to **records** or go out to clubs, while guitarists and flautists play their instruments right on the city streets. Some characters, like impulsive Dorcas and her friend Felice, find “dazzle and mischief” in the ever-changing music; others complain that jazz, with its brightness and force, makes people do “unwise disorderly things.” But no one in the novel can deny that live jazz is a kind of music uniquely built around surprise and improvisation, each performance invented in the moment and therefore irreplicable in the future.

This improvisational “essence” of jazz shows up in both the plot and structure of the narrative. At first, the novel’s unnamed narrator thinks she can predict exactly how Joe Trace’s torrid affair will unfold, believing he and Violet are “bound to the track [...] like a needle through the groove of a Bluebird record.” By the end of the story, however, Violet and Joe have found new pleasure and strength in each other, making the narrator realize that love, like live music, is “original, complicated, changeable—human.” Similarly, the novel itself mirrors the “changeable” structure of jazz, with all the solos, repetition, and variation inherent to the jazz genre. Rather than following a single linear narrative, *Jazz* moves back and forth through time and across perspectives, with different narrative voices taking over chunks of the story just as different soloists might take the stage in a jazz band. And the first few pages of the novel promise a tragedy that, by the end of the story, has failed to come to fruition, a formal surprise that shows a book can be

just as “original, complicated, changeable”—just as “improvisational”—as the human beings within it.



### MOTHERHOOD

Nearly every character in *Jazz*, Toni Morrison’s novel about a collapsing marriage in 1920s New York City, has lost his or her mother. After suffering years of poverty and violent anti-Black racism, protagonist Violet’s mother Rose Dear throws herself down a well when Violet is only 11 years old. Violet’s husband Joe has even less contact with his mother, a mysterious woman the townspeople call only “Wild.” And Dorcas, the young woman Joe has an affair with, loses both of her parents in the 1917 wave of anti-Black violence known the East St. Louis massacre. On the one hand, this lack of mothering makes Violet and her companions feel, to some extent, like permanent children: “Where the grown people?” Violet wonders aloud, “is it us?” But though the novel does not linger on even one biological mother-child relationship, many of the characters still find ways to extend motherly care to each other. Violet, post-menopausal but desperate for a baby, feels almost maternal towards the murdered Dorcas, even as she loathes her; later, she engages in more healthy mothering with Dorcas’ best friend Felice, cooking Felice dinner and cutting Felice’s hair. Dorcas’ aunt Alice Manfred is too strict a guardian to her niece—but after Dorcas’ death, Alice gets a second chance at motherhood in caring for Violet herself, patching her new friend’s torn clothes and helping her sort through her messiest feelings. By showing just how much mothering can exist outside the confines of a biological relationship, *Jazz* suggests a more expansive definition of motherhood and childhood, demonstrating that there is always someone in need of maternal care—and also always someone willing to extend it.



### RACIAL VIOLENCE AND PROTEST

Toni Morrison’s 1992 novel *Jazz* is set at the height of the Harlem Renaissance, and the story’s protagonists live in the prosperous, culturally flourishing Manhattan neighborhood that gives the movement its name. Yet even as the narrative celebrates the Black music and invention that surges on Harlem streets, it also demonstrates just how deeply anti-Black violence has shaped life for central character Joe Trace, his wife Violet, and his mistress Dorcas. Both Joe and Dorcas have seen their hometowns burned down, in each case because white people wanted to prevent Black property ownership; Violet’s mother Rose Dear, forcefully dispossessed of all of her belongings because of her husband’s voting rights activism, eventually threw herself down a well in desperation. And even the relatively peaceful bubble of Harlem is not entirely safe, as Joe learns when he is nearly beaten to death there in a sudden act of white violence.

The novel's unnamed narrator sees this horrific violence as somewhat intrinsic to the experience of Black life in America; when she sees a jazz musician on the street, she remarks that he is a "blues man. Black and bluesman. Blackandtherefore blues man." But if racial injustice and brutality is everywhere, *Jazz* also suggests that protest against these terrors can come in many forms, from a formal march down Fifth Avenue to the art of the Harlem Renaissance itself. Dorcas' aunt Alice Manfred, listening to the music that gives the novel its name, reflects that jazz is filled with a "complicated anger" and an "appetite," making her want to "snatch the world in her fist and squeeze the life out of it for doing what it did and did and did to her and everybody else she knew." In other words, the novel suggests that artistic creation—both jazz and *Jazz*—can contain protest and hope, giving listeners and readers a way to imagine and demand more, ultimately creating change.



### GOSSIP VS. KNOWLEDGE

From the very first page of Toni Morrison's *Jazz*, set in Jazz Age Harlem, the novel's unnamed narrator is confident that she understands her neighborhood perfectly. "Sth, I know that woman," she boasts, sequestering herself in her room as she tells readers about Violet Trace, and her husband Joe's secretive affair with a young woman named Dorcas. As the story progresses, the narrator goes even further, imagining herself into different times and regions of the United States to recount an entire invented family history for the Trace couple. But as the narrator watches the once-fractured duo reconcile after Joe's betrayal, she is stunned to realize that the sordid marital collapse she predicted could not be further from the truth. Though the narrator hears all of the neighborhood gossip through her apartment window, she is not privy to the intimacies Joe and Violet whisper to each other in bed; while she spends her time conjecturing from scandalous rumors, believing that "the past was an abused **record** with no choice but to repeat herself," Joe and Violet do not repeat history but consciously make an effort to change it. By the end of *Jazz*, therefore, the narrator is forced to realize that as long as she watches the world through her windowpane, no amount of gossiping, observing, or reading the newspaper can bring any real clarity about human behavior ("it infuriates me to discover," she muses, "how unreliable I am"). Instead, the novel suggests that it is only through relationships with others—through participating rather than watching—that people can fully "know" the people around them.



### BIRDS

Throughout *Jazz*, birds—particularly parrots—symbolize the pain of unrequited love. For years, as Violet and Joe find themselves increasingly isolated from each other, Violet speaks mostly to her parrot, whom she does not name; perhaps most saliently, when the parrot squawks "I love you," Violet never replies. Violet's inability to return her parrot's declarations of love echoes not only Violet's alienation from Joe, but also the alienation both of them have felt with their mothers—Violet because her mother Rose Dear committed suicide when Violet was a child, and Joe because his (probable) mother Wild never acknowledged him as her son. It is fitting, then, that in the beginning of the novel Violet and Joe banish the birds from their home, turning the now-empty bird cages in their apartment into an emblem of their shared (but unspoken) sense of loneliness. As the narrative progresses, however, Violet and Joe are able to articulate their mutual sense of abandonment and express their affection for each other, reciprocating love in exactly the way Violet was initially unable to do with her birds. And by the conclusion of *Jazz*, the Trace couple has decided to purchase a new bird, one they now carefully tend to and coo over—suggesting that this symbol of unrequited love has morphed into one of mutual care.



### RECORDS

In the novel *Jazz*, records represent the inevitability of human hurt and betrayal. Records are everywhere in 1920s Harlem, but unlike live jazz music, which makes room for improvisation and surprise, the recorded jazz music that plays on records is predestined, an endless, unchangeable loop of sound. For this reason, the novel's unnamed narrator often uses records as a metaphor for the tragedy she sees taking place between Joe, Violet, Dorcas, and Felice. At one point, the narrator reflects that Joe is "bound to the track" of his betrayal with Dorcas ("it pulls him like a needle through the groove of a Bluebird record"); at another point, she asserts that "the past was an abused record with no choice but to repeat itself." Indeed, the novel's climactic event—Joe's shooting of Dorcas at a party—is underscored by this sense of inevitable repetition, as Dorcas, losing consciousness, instructs her readers to "listen" to the record playing: "I don't know who is that woman singing," Dorcas remarks, "but I know the words by heart."

But as Joe and Violet diverge from the predictions the narrator made for them, reconciling instead of splitting for good, the narrator is forced to reckon with the fact that life is more like live jazz than its recorded counterpart. Instead of playing out their story like "an abused record," the narrator admits that the Trace couple was "busy being original, complicated, changeable—human, I'd guess you say." It is telling, then, that by the end of the narrative, Violet and Joe embrace not records



### SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.

but the live music they hear performed on the rooftops and streets, a testament to the unpredictability of real, “human” relationships.



## THE GREEN DRESS

The green dress that Golden Gray uses to cover Wild in *Jazz* comes to represent various character’s

desires for care—and their pain at feeling abandoned. The dress originates with the wealthy, white slaveholder Vera Louise, who wears it throughout her affair with Henry Lestory. Golden then inherits the dress from his mother, and he initially uses to cover Wild because he does not want the injured woman’s blood to dirty his coat. This callous (and racist) thought process upsets the novel’s unnamed narrator, who sees it as the ultimate evidence of Golden’s inability to think beyond himself. Years later, the dress takes on yet another meaning. When Joe Trace searches for Wild, whom he believes to be his mother, he stumbles upon the cave where she hides out, and he learns that Wild has held on to this green dress, alongside the doll and some other luxury items Golden gave to her. Later still, when the narrator reflects on the absence of love in her own life, she finds comfort in imagining Wild’s cave, in touching the green dress that might signal some incomplete form of care.

Because the dress appears in multiple settings and is often discussed in fragmentary, almost poetic language, its meaning is a source of debate among scholars; some experts argue that the dress also symbolizes history and memory, while others see it as a testament to the complex and painful legacies of slavery.

Joe Trace, Dorcas

**Related Themes:**



**Related Symbols:**



**Page Number:** 3

### Explanation and Analysis

In the opening lines of the novel, an unnamed narrator summarizes almost the entire plot of the story that will follow. First, then, this opener suggests that *Jazz* will have anything but a traditional structure; like jazz music itself, the novel begins with its main theme and then moves outward, adding variations and solos as it goes. The musical timbre of the writing is also evident in the prose style: “sth” is more sound than word, while phrases like “deep down, spooky love” and run-on sentences (“went to the funeral to see the girl and to cut her dead face they threw her to the floor and out of the church”) introduce readers to the sonorous rhythms of jazz.

Second, the gossipy tone of this introduction sets up the narrator’s confidence in her ability to understand her neighbors merely by watching them. The narrator takes an almost obsessive interest in Joe and Violet, describing the collapse of their marriage and the murder that followed with a sordid delight. But even though the narrator claims to “know that woman” and “know her husband, too,” it is also clear that there is an element of subjectivity to all this “knowledge”—like any lifelong gossip, the narrator might not be as reliable as she claims.

Third, the mention of Violet’s parrot serves to introduce, right away, one of the novel’s most crucial symbols. Violet’s parrot says, “I love you,” but rather than returning that statement of affection, Violet lets the parrot go. This focus on love, and particularly unrequited love, will come to be the central theme of the story. But while the narrator frames Violet’s decision to let her adoring parrot go as a clear sign of insanity and detachment, there is also a flicker of hope in the language—the freed birds might “freeze” to death, but they also might learn to “fly.”



## QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Vintage edition of *Jazz* published in 2004.

### Chapter 1 Quotes

☞ Sth, I know that woman. She used to live with a flock of birds on Lenox Avenue. Know her husband, too. He fell for an eighteen-year-old girl with one of those deep down, spooky loves that made him so sad and happy he shot her just to keep the feeling going. When the woman, her name is Violet, went to the funeral to see the girl and to cut her dead face they threw her to the floor and out of the church. She ran, then, through all that snow, and when she got back to her apartment she took the birds from their cages and set them out the windows to freeze or fly, including the parrot that said, “I love you.”

**Related Characters:** The Narrator (speaker), Violet Trace,

☞ The memory of the light, however, that had skipped through [Violet’s] veins came back now and then, and once in a while, on an overcast day, when certain corners in the room resisted lamplight; when the red beans in the pot seemed to be taking forever to soften, she imagined a brightness that could be carried in her arms. Distributed, if need be, into places as dark as the bottom of a well.



**Related Characters:** The Narrator (speaker), Violet Trace, Rose Dear

**Related Themes:** 

**Page Number:** 22

### Explanation and Analysis

When Violet holds a neighbor's baby for just a little longer than might be considered appropriate, rumors start going around Harlem that Violet meant to kidnap the child. But though Violet shakes these rumors off, the memory of holding the infant—and of “the light [...] that had skipped through her veins” as she did so—becomes a consistent source of comfort to her. In addition to signaling Violet's desire for a biological motherhood she is now too old for (the novel makes it clear that Violet has gone through menopause), this paragraph also highlights just how much Violet's understanding of family in adulthood is linked to domestic trauma in her childhood.

“The bottom of the well,” it will later be revealed, is where Violet's mother Rose Dear committed suicide. And though Violet has now built her own family home, far away from her birthplace in Virginia, painful memories of Rose's death still seem to haunt every inch of her space. When there is not enough “lamplight,” for example, “certain corners” of the house begin to feel as dark as the “bottom of the well”; the pot with the red beans might even recall the well's conical shape. And most of all, this passage emphasizes just how deeply Violet's own conflicting feelings about motherhood (her hesitancy to become a mother and her desire, “once in a while,” for her own baby to hold in her arms) are linked to the pain she feels at losing her mother so young.

**Related Characters:** The Narrator (speaker), Violet Trace, Joe Trace

**Related Themes:** 

**Page Number:** 33

### Explanation and Analysis

In the decades after the Civil War, thousands of Black men and women immigrated to New York City, fleeing Reconstruction era white violence in the South (and in some northern parts of the United States, too). Here, Morrison emphasizes that part of what made “the City” such an easy place to love was the brutal “specter” of this violence that these new New Yorkers were trying to leave behind.

To gesture towards the pervasive, complex horrors of anti-Black discrimination, the narrator cites several specific examples. The “27th Battalion” refers to an all-Black infantry regiment in Ohio, commanded by white soldiers, that fought for the Union in the Civil War. Despite the battlefield dangers that the Black soldiers subjected themselves to, they were paid far less than their white counterparts, and were ineligible for advancement or bonuses. Then, after the war ended, these infantrymen were told by their generals that they might be expelled from Ohio by white violence—as if this were a fact rather than an atrocity.

This economic injustice continued all the county. Armour, Swift, Mallory and Montgomery Ward were all Gilded Age entrepreneurs who exploited the Black laborers they employed. And the reference to “raving whites” who “foamed all over the lanes and yards at home” speaks to the disenfranchisement, theft, and intimidation that white people used to deny Black people political power and property. Later, Joe and Violet will both reveal that they repeatedly lost their homes and sources of income to this sort of white violence.

## Chapter 2 Quotes

☛☛ Part of why they loved it was the specter they left behind. The slumped spines of the veterans of the 27th Battalion betrayed by the commander for whom they had fought like lunatics. The eyes of thousands, stupefied with disgust at having been imported by Mr. Armour, Mr. Swift, Mr. Montgomery Ward to break strikes then dismissed for having done so. The broken shoes of two thousand Galveston longshoremen that Mr. Mallory would never pay fifty cents an hour like the white ones. The praying palms, the raspy breathing, the quiet children of the ones who had escaped from Springfield Ohio, Springfield Indiana, Greensburg Indiana, Wilmington Delaware, New Orleans Louisiana, after raving whites had foamed all over the lanes and yards at home.

☛ So why is it on Thursday that the men look satisfied? Perhaps it's the artificial rhythm of the week—perhaps there is something so phony about the seven-day cycle the body pays no attention to it, preferring triplets, duets, quartets, anything but a cycle of seven that has to be broken into human parts and the break comes on Thursday. Irresistible. The outrageous expectations and inflexible demands of the weekend are null on Thursday. People look forward to weekends for connections, revisions and separations even though many of these activities are accompanied by bruises and even a spot of blood, for excitement runs high on Friday or Saturday.

But for satisfaction pure and deep, for balance and pleasure and comfort, Thursday can't be beat.

**Related Characters:** The Narrator (speaker), Joe Trace, Dorcas

**Related Themes:**  

**Page Number:** 50

### Explanation and Analysis

Describing Joe's happiness in his affair with the much-younger Dorcas, the narrator notes that he became a "Thursday man," always "satisfied" because he was always either remembering his last meeting with Dorcas or looking forward to his next one. In this elegant passage, the novel explicitly notes that "human" life and romance conform more to the rhythms of jazz music—"triplets, duets, quartets"—than to the "artificial rhythm" that defines a standard work week. This idea that people are unpredictable, not "inflexible" but able to bend themselves in surprising ways, will become increasingly important over the course of the narrative.

It is also worth noting the difference between Joe's quiet desires and the "outrageous expectations" of the weekend (which Dorcas will be seen to embody). Whereas Joe wants to find some kind of stable romance, filled with "balance and pleasure and comfort," Dorcas—perhaps because of her youth, or because of her painful childhood—craves the "bruises" of weekend drama, which involves "revisions and separations" and unreciprocated attraction. This tension between peaceful love and thrilling "connection" will ultimately account for the central rift between Joe and Dorcas.

## Chapter 3 Quotes

☛ She knew from sermons and editorials that it wasn't real music—just colored folks' stuff [...]

Yet Alice Manfred swore she heard a complicated anger in it; something hostile that disguised itself as flourish and roaring seduction. But the part she hated most was its appetite. [...] It made her hold her hand in the pocket of her apron to keep from smashing it through the glass pane to snatch the world in her fist and squeeze the life out of it for doing what it did and did and did to her and everybody else she knew [...]

I don't know how she did it—balance herself with two different hand gestures. But she was not alone in trying, and she was not alone in losing. It was impossible to keep the Fifth Avenue drums separate from the belt-buckle tunes vibrating from pianos and spinning on every Victrola. Impossible.

**Related Characters:** The Narrator (speaker), Alice Manfred

**Related Themes:**  

**Page Number:** 59

### Explanation and Analysis

Alice Manfred, scarred from the traumatic white violence that killed her sister and brother-in-law, seems to feel that the safest way to navigate the world is to internalize some of the prejudice that haunts her (i.e., dismissing jazz as "just colored folks' stuff" and therefore "not real"). But even as Alice tries to shrug off the jazz music, preferring instead to focus on organized civil rights protests like the famed NAACP Silent Parade (and "the Fifth Avenue drums" that went with it), she has to acknowledge that jazz is itself a form of protest. Indeed, every time Alice hears jazz, she feels the music's "appetite" for a different and more equal future, hears its anger that makes her want to "smash" the world for its endless brutality ("what it did and did and did to her and everybody else").

Crucially, the narrator suggests that Alice is "not alone" in trying to balance the conflicting emotions that jazz sparks, or in trying to make her way through a world so unfair that it makes her want to "squeeze the life out of it." Even "the belt-buckle tunes" that seem, on the surface, to be an escape carry the pounding desire for change symbolized by those "Fifth Avenue drums." And no matter how much Alice tries to ignore that inequity or bury her rage at it—as much as she tries to roll her eyes at jazz and all that it stands for—it will always be "impossible" to do so.

☛ The brothers turn up the wattage of their smiles. The right record is on the turntable now; [Dorcas] can hear its preparatory hiss as the needle slides through its first groove. The brothers smiles brilliantly; one leans a fraction of an inch toward the other and, never losing eye contact with Dorcas, whispers something. [...] Then, just as the music, slow and smoky, loads up the air, his smile bright as ever, he wrinkles his nose and turns away.

Dorcas has been acknowledged, appraised and dismissed in the time it takes for a needle to find its opening groove. The stomach jump of possible love is nothing compared to the ice flows that block upper veins now. The body she inhabits is unworthy. [...]

So by the time Joe Trace whispered to her through the crack of a closing door her life had become almost unbearable.

**Related Characters:** The Narrator (speaker), Joe Trace, Dorcas

**Related Themes:**  

**Related Symbols:** 

**Page Number:** 67

### Explanation and Analysis

Dorcas, attending one of her first ever “adult parties,” is instantly infatuated with the two handsome brothers who command the dance floor. But as one brother “wrinkles his nose” to the other, neither one of these desirable men decides to return Dorcas’ affections; instead, they “appraise” and “dismiss” her, making her feel disposable and “unworthy.” And as the narrator makes explicit here, Dorcas’ pain and humiliation (“the ice flows” that form in her veins) drives her directly to Joe Trace himself, his adoration the only route away from her “unbearable” feelings of rejection.

Tellingly, the narrator describes Dorcas’ tragic path to Joe as almost predestined, as if her fate is beyond her control. It is fitting, then, that this encounter with the brothers is underscored by a record, the needle “finding” and then sliding “through its first groove” as inevitably as Dorcas approaches (and then is turned down by) the two dashing brothers. And while the overarching structure of *Jazz* may contest the narrator’s belief that all of life is as predictable as a record on a turntable, Dorcas seems to share this view of herself as a doomed heroine, destined for excitement—and then for tragedy.

☛ Everyone needs a pile of newspapers: to peel potatoes on, serve bathroom needs, wrap garbage. But not like Alice Manfred. She must have read them over and over else why would she keep them? And if she read anything in the newspaper twice she knew too little about too much. If you have secrets you want kept or want to figure out those other people have, a newspaper can turn your mind. The best thing to find out what’s going on is to watch how people maneuver themselves in the streets [...]

But Alice Manfred wasn’t the kind to give herself reasons to be in the streets. [...] If she had come out more often, sat on the stoop or gossiped in front of the beauty shop, she would have known more than what the paper said she might have known what was happening under her nose.

**Related Characters:** The Narrator (speaker), Joe Trace, Alice Manfred, Dorcas

**Related Themes:**   

**Page Number:** 72

### Explanation and Analysis

Given all that transpires between Joe and Dorcas, the narrator blames Alice Manfred for not noticing or predicting the affair more quickly. But even as the narrator criticizes Alice for reading the newspapers “over and over” instead of going on out on the stoop or “gossiping,” the novel suggests that Alice’s decision to remove herself from the street-life of New York City makes perfect sense. After all, Alice has lost her sister and brother-in-law to white violence; in some ways, she also lost her husband twice (first to his betrayal and then when he, too, died). No wonder she “wasn’t the kind to give herself reasons to be in the streets”; how could Alice “come out” of doors when she had seen, firsthand, how dangerous “out” could be?

Moreover, it is vital to spot the parallels between the Alice and the narrator herself. Though the narrator believes that the remove of newspaper-reading and secondhand-news can confuse people (“turn your mind” or teach you “too little about too much”), she similarly removes herself from the world, preferring to watch from her window rather than coming onto the streets or the stoops. And so Alice’s naivete about her niece’s affair with Joe foreshadows the narrator’s eventual discovery that she, too, has been unable to predict what would happen to the people she thought were right “under her nose.”

## Chapter 4 Quotes

☝ All she saw, down in the cellar well beneath the stoop, was a light yellow feather with a tip of green. And she had never named him. Had called him my parrot all these years. “My parrot.” “Love you.” “Love you.” Did the dogs get him? Did some night-walking man snatch him up and take him to a house that did not feature mirrors or keep a supply of ginger cookies for him? Or did he get the message—that she said, “my parrot” and he said, “love you,” and she had never said it back or even taken the trouble to name him—and manage somehow to fly away.

**Related Characters:** The Narrator (speaker), Violet Trace, Dorcas

**Related Themes:** 

**Related Symbols:** 

**Page Number:** 93

**Explanation and Analysis**

After Joe falls in love with Dorcas and then kills her, Violet feels that all the birds and parrots she and Joe used to keep are now a too-painful reminder of their former happiness. But after letting the birds go (including the parrot who always chirped “love you”), Violet seems to feel some measure of regret. Even though Violet cannot openly reciprocate her parrot’s declaration of love, her affection for this creature is clear in the “mirrors” she lays out for him and the “supply of ginger cookies” she feeds him with. And though Violet did not ever “take the trouble” to name the parrot, she still thought of him as hers, hoping for loyalty that she could not “name.”

On the one hand, Violet’s relationship with this parrot signals her general inability to articulate care even when she actually feels it. But on the other hand, Violet’s regrets here clearly symbolize and stand in for some of her regrets about her relationship with Joe. Just as she called her parrot “my parrot,” Violet trusted that Joe would remain hers and hers alone, making his betrayal with Dorcas feel profoundly shocking. And though Violet tried to make her care for Joe felt in the same way she tried to show the parrot she returned its feelings (decorating their home, making Joe food), in both cases, the relationships end up feeling lopsided and unreciprocated. This story with the parrot thus gives tangible shape to the novel’s fascination with unrequited feelings, with the pervasive pain of saying “I love you” to someone who does not (or cannot) say it back.

Lastly, the fact that Violet now steps into the narrator’s role, telling the story from her own first-person perspective,

speaks to the novel’s jazz-like structure. Just as pianists or saxophonists might take a solo in a jazz band, Violet is taking her solo, sharing her view on the novel’s central theme.

☝ What did she see, young girl like that, barely out of high school, with unbraided hair, lip rouge for the first time and high-heeled shoes? And also what did he? A young me with high-yellow skin instead of black? A young me with long wave hair instead of short? Or a not me at all. A me he was loving in Virginia because that girl Dorcas wasn’t around there anywhere. Was that it? [...] Is that what happened? Standing in the cane, he was trying to catch a girl he was yet to see, but his heart knew all about, and me, holding on to him but wishing he was the golden boy I never saw either. Which means from the very beginning I was a substitute and so was he.

**Related Characters:** Violet Trace (speaker), Joe Trace, Dorcas, True Belle, Golden Gray

**Related Themes:**   

**Page Number:** 97

**Explanation and Analysis**

Violet, sipping a malted milk to try and gain back the curves she remembers having from her youth, now obsesses over the specifics of Joe’s desire for Dorcas. In addition to being angry at (and isolated from) Joe, Violet’s thoughts here also reveal how far away she feels from her own self, from any sense of stable identity. For example, Violet confuses her persona and Dorcas’, calling the younger woman a “not me”; she compares her own skin unfavorably to Dorcas’ lighter skin tone, wondering if Joe’s betrayal stems from pervasive colorism. And the fact that Violet is forcing this malted down her throat as she thinks suggests that she is deeply uncomfortable in her own skin (as she literally tries to alter her own physical form).

Even more importantly, Violet now comes to realize that she and Joe’s relationship was unbalanced and unreciprocated long before Dorcas entered the picture. Violet wonders if Joe was always looking for someone else, a “not me” alternative to Violet. And for her part, Violet admits that she was not even seeking Joe when she first ended up with him. Instead, she was chasing after Golden Gray, a symbol of whiteness and wealth that her grandmother True Belle always romanticized. So while Violet can see that Joe’s romantic desires are confused, his childhood needs mixing with his adult wants, she has to admit that her desires seem to function in the same way.



☞ The important thing, the biggest thing Violet got out of that was to never never have children. Whatever happened, no small dark foot would rest on another while a hungry mouth said, Mama?

**Related Characters:** The Narrator (speaker), Violet Trace, Rose Dear

**Related Themes:**  

**Page Number:** 102

### Explanation and Analysis

Violet, recalling her childhood with pain, especially remembers the way her mother Rose Dear collapsed after their family home was repossessed. Because Rose Dear—feeling defeated, with a missing husband and her property stolen—was unresponsive and unable to provide for her children, Violet and her siblings often went hungry. And haunted by these memories, Violet is desperate to ensure that she will never repeat her mother's fate. In other words, in order to make sure she never has children who go hungry, Violet decides to never have any children at all.

The narrator makes it clear, however, that by the time the novel begins, Violet is desperate for children, yet another token that knowledge of the past does not make it possible to predict the present. And so Violet's decision (made in her youth) to never have children mostly reflects just how deeply Violet's memories of Rose Dear have scarred her. Perhaps the word "Mama" is treated as a question because Violet is always in search of a mother figure, in need of someone who can provide the kind of emotional sustenance she is she "hungry" for. And though, after the events of Dorcas' funeral, Violet is an object of fear for many of her neighbors in Harlem, this scene makes it clear how much childlike vulnerability the grown-up Violet still feels.

☞ Who lay there asleep in that coffin? Who posed there awake in the photograph? The scheming bitch who had not considered Violet's feelings one tiniest bit, who came into her life, took what she wanted and damn the consequences? Or Mama's dumpling girl? Was she the woman who took the man, or the daughter who fled her womb? Washed away on a tide of soap, salt and castor oil. Terrified, perhaps, of so violent a home. Unaware that, had it failed, had she braved mammy-made poisons and mammy's urgent fists, she could have had the best dressed hair in the city.

**Related Characters:** The Narrator (speaker), Violet Trace,

Joe Trace, Dorcas

**Related Themes:**  

**Page Number:** 109

### Explanation and Analysis

Now, still sipping her malted, Violet begins to knit her longing for maternal care and motherhood together with the obsessive envy she feels for Dorcas. Violet has previously allowed herself only to see Dorcas with resentment, blaming all of her curiosity about how this young girl lived (what she liked to eat, her favorite dance moves, her hairstyles) on the fact that Dorcas had "schem[ed]" to get Joe away from Violet. But when Violet does the math, she realizes that Dorcas would have born around the same time as the fetuses she conceived and aborted (through "mammy-made poison" and "mammy's urgent fists"). In other words, Violet must now admit that part of her fascination with Dorcas is because she sees this young woman as a kind of surrogate daughter, a "dumpling girl" whose hair Violet would make "the best dressed [...] in the city."

As in many moments in this crucial chapter, Violet's discovery here—of how each person's past informs and confuses their present—represents one of the novel's central insights. But by acknowledging just how much her trauma as a child has impacted her, Violet is also able to start to process and heal from this pain. Indeed, by embracing the contradictions inherent in Dorcas' face, Violet does not have to decide whether the girl in the picture on the mantle was "the woman who took the man" or "the daughter who fled [Violet's] womb." Instead, Violet can feel both of her feelings at the same time, and, in doing so, move from the past of her memories into the everyday present of "the City."

☞ "Oh shoot! Where the grown people? Is it us?"

"Oh, Mama." Alice Manfred blurted it out and then covered her mouth.

Violet had the same thought: Mama. Mama? Is this where you got to and couldn't do it no more? The place of shade without trees where you know you are not and never again will be loved by anybody who can choose to do it? Where everything is over about the talking? They looked away from each other then. The silence went on and on until Alice Manfred said, "Give me that coat. I can't look at that lining another minute."

**Related Characters:** Violet Trace, The Narrator, Alice

Manfred (speaker), Joe Trace, Rose Dear, Violet's Father

**Related Themes:**  

**Page Number:** 110

### Explanation and Analysis

After Alice Manfred encourages Violet to be more mature, Violet wonders if either of them will ever actually feel like “grown” adults. Though this back-and-forth between the two women is in part merely a warm moment of bonding, it also signals their very real discovery that adulthood is not something one can ever fully arrive in—just as childhood is not something one can ever fully leave. And indeed, Violet is clearly still haunted by the memories of her mother Rose Dear's death (“is there where you got to and couldn't do it no more?” Violet wonders, thinking back on the moment her mother killed herself by jumping down a well).

At first, Violet's private thoughts suggest her own anxiety that she is ending up like her mother; just as Rose Dear felt abandoned by Violet's father, Violet fears that her recent fissure with Joe means that she, too, will “never again [...] be loved by anybody who can choose to do it.” Then, however, Violet and Alice find a great deal of comfort in recognizing their mutual desire to find a “Mama.” And because of that recognition, the two women are able to start acting almost like surrogate mothers to each other, offering advice and comfort and even material support. After all, what could be more tenderly maternal than Alice's insistence that she must mend Violet's tattered coat because she “can't look at that lining another minute?” For as Alice and Violet both muse about that word “Mama,” they are able to simultaneously crave and emulate the maternal love at the fronts of their minds.

hears a musician playing the flute. This passage is important largely because it epitomizes the way Morrison makes music not only the content but the form of *Jazz*; as the words combine with legato ease (Blackandblues) or break into staccato bursts (where-did-she-go-and-why), Morrison's prose beautifully mimics the rhythmic phrasing of jazz.

There are three other details to note in this passage. First, the repeated phrase “everybody knows your name” acts as another reminder of how much neighborly gossip circulates in the streets and at the windows. Second, the topics of the songs—about a man whose beloved seems to have left him—echoes the novel's thematic interest in unrequited love. And third, the phrase “Blackthereforeblue man” hints at the dangers wrought by white supremacy on Black lives. Even in this seemingly joyful music, then, the narrator hears in the blues what Alice Manfred does in jazz: a testament to the pain and inequity of living as a Black person in a society so infected by racism.

☛ I tracked my mother in Virginia and it led me right to her, and I tracked Dorcas from borough to borough. I didn't even have to work at it. Didn't even have to think. Something else takes over when the track begins to talk to you, give out its signs so strong you hardly have to look [...] If the trail speaks, no matter what's in the way, you can find yourself in a crowded room aiming a bullet at her heart, never mind it's the heart you can't live without [...]

I wasn't looking for the trail. It was looking for me and when it started talking at first I couldn't hear it. I was rambling, just rambling all through the city. I had the gun but it was not the gun—it was my hand I wanted to touch you with.

## Chapter 5 Quotes

☛ Blues man. Blackandblues man. Blackthereforeblue man.

Everybody knows your name. Where-did-she-go-and-why man. So-lonesome-I-could-die-man.

Everybody knows your name.

**Related Characters:** The Narrator (speaker), Alice Manfred

**Related Themes:**    

**Page Number:** 119

### Explanation and Analysis

As the narrator walks down the sidewalk in Harlem, she

**Related Characters:** Joe Trace (speaker), The Narrator, Dorcas, The Woman/Wild, Henry Lestory/Hunter's Hunter, Victory Williams

**Related Themes:**    

**Related Symbols:** 

**Page Number:** 130

### Explanation and Analysis

In this section of the novel, written from Joe's perspective (his jazz ‘solo’ of sorts), Joe recounts the complex emotions that led him to shoot and kill Dorcas. Suspecting that Dorcas had started seeing another man, Joe “tracked [her] from borough to borough,” just as he had learned to track

prey in his days hunting with Henry Lestory and Victory. But as Joe emphasizes, this tracking is far from rational. He “didn’t even have to think” because the trail was “speaking” to him; he didn’t plan to go to the “crowded room” where Dorcas was dancing with another man, he just “found” himself there.

The blur of these events helps explain the confused motives behind the novel’s central murder. Joe is desperate to connect with Dorcas: her heart is “the heart [he] can’t live without,” and his violence is actually his misguided attempt to “touch” her or reunite with her. But Morrison goes one step further, letting Joe explicitly link his confusion in this adult intimate relationship to the abandonment he felt with his mother, Wild. Joe learned that the tracking strategies he had learned as a hunter could get him proximity to Wild (“I tracked my mother in Virginia and it led me right to her”), so why wouldn’t the same strategy work with Dorcas? And now, it is evident exactly how much Joe’s relationship with Wild has knitted everything together: past and present, closeness and obsession, even touch and violence.

Lastly, it is important that Joe uses the word “track” here to describe his focus on Dorcas. The narrator will frequently compare Joe’s fixation on Dorcas to a “record bound to the track,” doomed to repeat the same tragic patterns over and over. So Joe’s “tracking” of Dorcas here takes on new meanings—it references his hunter days, but it also gestures towards the narrator’s claim that all of this horror was inevitable to begin with, a record going around in a loop.

**Page Number:** 142

### Explanation and Analysis

Here, the narrator zooms out to tell the story of Violet’s grandmother True Belle. True Belle was enslaved by Vera Louise’s family and forced to leave Virginia with Vera when Vera’s parents disowned her. Previously, True Belle’s stories about her time in Baltimore with Vera and her son Golden Gray have made this era of her life seem luxurious and romantic; for years, Violet has treasured her grandmother’s exotic tales. But in this passage, it is clear just how much True Belle has had to talk herself into these stories, trying to make the best of a situation that she in fact had no agency in.

Indeed, Vera has all the legal and financial power; even in her darkest moment (when her parents kick her out because of her pregnancy), she has “a lot of [paper money] handed to her.” Vera decides that she “wanted” True Belle and “takes” her, ignoring the fact that True Belle has a full family of her own; Vera makes choices and then more choices, while True Belle remains “choiceless,” not even allowed to see “the land” she has been forced to travel to. And in a story so much about motherhood and the absence of maternal care, True Belle’s “choiceless” departure makes clear that white supremacy can show itself in more intimate, familial forms of violence, too—in order to make it easier for her to mother her own son, Vera Louise denies True Belle’s own daughters access to their mother entirely.

## Chapter 6 Quotes

☞ True Belle was the one [Vera] wanted and the one she took. I don’t know how hard it was for a slave woman to leave a husband that work and distance kept her from seeing much of anyhow, and to leave two daughters behind with an old aunt to take care of them. Rose Dear and May were eight and ten years old then. [...]

More important, Miss Vera Louise might help her buy them all out with paper money, because she sure had a lot of it handed to her. Then again, maybe not. Maybe she frowned as she sat in the baggage car, rocking along with the boxes and trunks, unable to see the land she was traveling through. Maybe she felt bad. Anyway, choiceless, she went.

**Related Characters:** The Narrator (speaker), Violet Trace, True Belle, Golden Gray, Vera Louise, Rose Dear

**Related Themes:**  

☞ [Golden thought of] the woman who cooked and cleaned for Vera Louise; who sent baskets of plum preserves, ham and loaves of bread every week while he was in boarding school; who gave his frayed shirts to rag and bone men rather than let him wear them; the woman who smiled and shook her head every time she looked at him. [...] When the two of them, the whitewoman and the cook, bathed him they sometimes passed anxious looks at the palms of his hand, the texture of his drying hair. Well, Vera Louise was anxious, True Belle just smiled, and now he knew what she was smiling about, that nigger. But so was he. He had always thought there was only one kind—True Belle’s kind. Black and nothing. Like Henry Lestory. Like the filthy woman snoring on the cot. But there was another kind—like himself.

**Related Characters:** The Narrator (speaker), True Belle, Golden Gray, Henry Lestory/Hunter’s Hunter, Vera Louise

**Related Themes:**   

**Page Number:** 149**Explanation and Analysis**

Golden, having recently learned that his father is a Black man, tries to sort through his own private feelings about race and racism. On a factual level, Golden is now combing his memories for evidence of his identity, realizing that Vera and True Belle had spent his entire life worrying he would cease to be white-passing (that “the texture of his drying hair” or “the palms of his hand” would reveal him). But even as Golden grapples with his own shifting view of himself, the severity of his racial prejudice shines through in the very way this passage is structured.

First, Golden (or the narrator) reflects on all the vital little kindnesses True Belle has shown Golden throughout his life: her smiles, her plum preserves, her commitment to keeping him only in the freshest shirts. Still, despite the fact that Golden seems to have felt an intimacy with True Belle that he never shared with his own mother, he erases her personhood entirely. He refers to her by a violently hateful racial slur, and describes her as “Black and nothing,” a sentence structure that treats those two words as synonyms. And he talks about her as if she were an animal (“True Belle’s kind”), a kind of horrific human taxonomy that Golden tosses out casually. The novel’s interest in unrequited love thus takes on a new cast: even seemingly intimate relationships like the one between Golden and True Belle are deformed by white supremacy. On the one hand, True Belle is forced into her kindness; on the other hand, Golden is too blinded by racialized hatred to receive or really acknowledge that kindness.

☝ What was I thinking of? How could I have imagined him so poorly? Not notice the hurt that was not linked to the color of his skin, or the blood that beat beneath it. But to some other thing that longed for authenticity, for a right to be in this place, effortlessly without needing to acquire a false face, a laughless grin, a talking posture. I have been careless and stupid and it infuriates me to discover (again) how unreliable I am.

**Related Characters:** The Narrator (speaker), Violet Trace, Joe Trace, Golden Gray, Henry Lestory/Hunter’s Hunter, Vera Louise

**Related Themes:**   

**Page Number:** 151**Explanation and Analysis**

As the narrator tries to make sense of what happened between Joe and Violet, she dives further and further into conjecture, summoning a fantasy of Golden Gray and then rejecting her own imaginings of him. Here, Morrison complicates the idea of the “unreliable” narrator trope; rather than trying to deceive her readers, as most unreliable narrators do, the narrator is doing her best to be reliable. And the more the narrator of *Jazz* realizes the deficiencies of her method—the impossibility, in other words, of “imagining” correctly only from gossip and observation—the more frustrated she becomes. The narrator’s fury here thus signals just how high the stakes of her narration have become: if it makes the narrator feel confident and connected to have perfect knowledge (as is clear from her opening brag, “sth, I know that woman”), it is destabilizing and alienating when she feels “stupid.”

This passage thus points to the narrator’s investment in her story, which seems to help her shed the loneliness or self-doubt that otherwise nips at her heels. But it also illuminates that Golden, too, is struggling with the yearning for family that crushes Violet and Joe, “long[ing] for authenticity” he cannot find anywhere else. Moreover, as the narrator identifies Golden’s hunger for “authenticity,” she also links adult artifice (the “false faces” people put on) to their lack of family ties in childhood, a connection Violet and Joe will later similarly draw for themselves.

**Chapter 7 Quotes**

☝ Had she run away, escaped? Or had she been overtaken by smoke, fire, panic, helplessness? [...] Immediately Joe fell to his hands and knees, whispering: “Is it you? Just say it. Say anything.” Someone near him was breathing. Turning around he examined the place he had just exited. Every movement and leaf shift seemed to be her. “Give me a sign, then you don’t have to say nothing. Let me see your hand. Just stick it out someplace and I’ll go; I promise. A sign.” He begged, pleaded for her hand until the light grew even smaller. “You my mother?” Yes. No. Both. Either. But not this nothing.

**Related Characters:** The Narrator (speaker), Violet Trace, Joe Trace, Dorcas, The Woman/Wild

**Related Themes:**    

**Page Number:** 178**Explanation and Analysis**

After years of searching for Wild, the woman rumored to be his mother, Joe—using the skills he learned as a hunter—at

last thinks he has gotten close to her. Joe's desperation to have some kind of contact with this parental figure is touching: "say anything," he begs, though he will also accept if Wild says "nothing" at all and gives him a non-verbal "sign" instead. But despite Joe's pleading, Wild will not respond to him—a rejection that will later shape both Joe's relationship with Violet and, even more painfully, his courtship of Dorcas.

There are a few other details worth noting in this passage. First, the "smoke, fire, panic, helplessness" Joe mentions is another reference to the white violence that pervaded the South in the Reconstruction Era, part of an effort to dispossess Black landowners and ensure white hegemony. Second, Joe's use of his "tracking skills" (noting the movement of the leaves, crawling on the ground, waiting to hear "breathing") further links this moment with Wild to the moment when he tries to "track" Dorcas down in New York. And finally, the sentence fragments at the end of the passage—"Yes. No. Both. Either"—once more give the passage a musical quality, as if Joe's pain is too great to fit into the grammatical rules of standard prose.

●● Although it was a private place, with an opening closed to the public, once inside you could do what you pleased: disrupt things, rummage, touch and move. Change it all to a way it was never meant to be. The color of the stone walls had changed from gold to fishkill blue by the time he left. [Joe] had seen what there was. A green dress. A rocking chair without an arm. A circle of stones for cooking. [...] Also. Also, a pair of man's trousers with buttons of bone. Carefully folded, a silk shirt, faded pale and creamy—except at the seams. There, both thread and fabric were fresh and sunny yellow.

But where is *she*?

**Related Characters:** Joe Trace, The Narrator (speaker), The Woman/Wild

**Related Themes:**  

**Related Symbols:** 

**Page Number:** 184

### Explanation and Analysis

Though Joe never gets the moment of recognition or response that he so craves from Wild, his suspected mother, he does eventually find his way into the cave where she sleeps. Despite Wild's seeming remove from society, the objects Joe sees here—the symbolic "green dress" that

Golden once used to cover Wild, the fancy household items that Golden brought from Baltimore—suggest that Wild, too, treasures her memories of care and intimacy. And just as Joe keeps hoping he will find his mother ("but where is *she*?" he wonders), Wild seems to hold onto some hope that Golden will return, that she can reunite with the man who fits those "trousers" and that "silk shirt."

It is also important that Wild's cave, which initially seems almost hermetically sealed, is still a place where someone like Joe can "disrupt things, rummage, touch and move." No one, the novel therefore seems to suggest, no matter how much they try to remove themselves from the world, is safe from the unpredictability of life; the narrator might envy Wild her separation, but even Wild's cave can be "touched" and "disrupted" and "moved" from its original state.

## Chapter 8 Quotes

●● They agree on everything above the waist and below: muscle, tendon, bone joint and marrow cooperate. And if the dancers hesitate, have a moment of doubt, the music will solve and dissolve any question.

Dorcas is happy. Happier than she has ever been any time. No white strands grow in her partner's mustache. He is up and coming. Hawk-eyed, tireless and a little cruel. He has never given her a present or even thought about it. Sometimes he is where he says he will be; sometimes not. Other women want him—badly—and he has been selective. What they want and the prize it is his to give is his savvy self. What could a pair of silk stockings be compared to him? No contest. Dorcas is lucky. Knows it. And is as happy as she has ever been any time.

**Related Characters:** The Narrator (speaker), Joe Trace, Dorcas, Acton

**Related Themes:**  

**Related Symbols:** 

**Page Number:** 188

### Explanation and Analysis

The narrative rewinds to the events of the night Dorcas was killed, when she attended a party with her new lover Acton. As the young couple dances to the music on the record player, it becomes clear that melody—and particularly jazz melody—can speak to the body as much or more than it speaks to the mind. Indeed, though there seems to be a good amount of tension in Dorcas' relationship with Acton



(he is described as “a little cruel” to her), they are able to sync up through the music; their personalities are at odds, but “muscle, tendon, bone, joint and marrow cooperate.” It is appropriate, then, that a novel so concerned with how sex can deepen or transform emotional intimacy takes the word *Jazz* as its title.

It is also important to spot how Dorcas compares Acton, favorably, to Joe. While Joe is kind to her, plying her with “silk stockings” and showing up whenever she wants him, Acton is harsh and unreliable; while Joe is older and experienced, with “white strands” in his mustache, Acton is young and arrogant. But Dorcas, illustrating the novel’s suggestion that unrequited love is often the most tempting attraction of all, seems drawn to Acton precisely because he is difficult to pin down. Acton makes Dorcas think, at least some of the time, that he has “selected” her—and after being made to feel “unworthy,” Acton’s choosy difficulty makes Dorcas “happier” than Joe’s constant adoration ever could.

☛ I want to sleep, but it is clear now. So clear the dark bowl the pile of oranges. Just oranges. Bright. Listen. I don’t know who is that woman singing but I know the words by heart.

**Related Characters:** Dorcas (speaker), Joe Trace, Acton

**Related Themes:** 

**Related Symbols:** 

**Page Number:** 193

### Explanation and Analysis

When Joe shoots Dorcas, the novel temporarily jolts into her perspective, a troublingly hazy, first-person recounting of a death. Stylistically, it is worth noting that the fragmentary sentences Morrison has been using to mimic jazz—“so clear the dark bowl the pile of oranges,” muses Dorcas, more in poetry than prose—now come to signal the loss of consciousness Dorcas experiences as she dies.

More important, however, is the fact that Dorcas is listening to music (earlier specified to be pre-taped jazz on a record) as she dies. Throughout the novel, the narrator has used records as a symbol for inevitable doom: she describes Joe’s life and relationship with Dorcas as “a record bound to the track,” unable to change direction or make room for surprise. Though the novel ultimately contests this idea of tragic fate, Dorcas’ death does play out exactly as the narrator might have predicted it would. So it is only fitting

that Dorcas, even as she hazily bleeds out, feels like there is something familiar: she might not know the voice on the recording, but she has heard this song enough times to “know the words by heart.”

## Chapter 9 Quotes

☛ The way she said it. Not like the ‘me’ was some tough somebody, or somebody she had put together for show. But like, like somebody she favored and could count on. A secret somebody you didn’t have to feel sorry for or have to fight for. Somebody who wouldn’t have to steal a ring to get back at white people and then lie and say it was a present from them. I wanted the ring back not just because my mother asks me have I found it yet. It’s beautiful. But although it belongs to me, it’s not mine. I love it, but there’s a trick in it and I have to agree to the trick to say it’s mine. Reminds me of the tricky blonde kid living inside Mrs. Trace’s head. A present taken from white folks, given to me when I was too young to say No thank you.

**Related Characters:** Felice (speaker), Violet Trace, Joe Trace, The Narrator, Golden Gray

**Related Themes:** 

**Page Number:** 210

### Explanation and Analysis

Felice now takes a turn narrating the novel (her ‘solo’), visiting Joe and Violet at home and using the occasion to observe Violet’s newfound self-confidence. In particular, Felice is struck by the way that Violet exists privately; the sense of herself (the “me”) that fills Violet with pride is a “a secret somebody,” not “put together for show” but revealed only to Violet and the people she trusts (like Joe and Felice). No wonder, then, that the narrator failed to predict or understand Violet’s motivations. How could she, when the “me” Violet realized she could “count on”—even when the other people in her life had abandoned or betrayed her—was kept out of sight?

Additionally, Felice now makes an explicit connection between the confused loves various characters have experienced and the overwhelming presence of anti-Black racism. Felice’s mother loves that Tiffany ring (which she stole), and Violet worshipped Golden Gray, but in both cases, those delights had more to do with white supremacist ideology than with any inherent beauty in the ring or in the boy. Felice thus seems to suggest that part of healing for Violet, Joe, and the rest of the people in *Jazz* involves acknowledging the “trick” of racism, a trick that asks

everyone in a racist society to “agree” to it every day. And if Felice now can say “No thank you” to that trick, this passage implies, it is because Violet modeled for her how to do so.

again. Instead of signifying Joe and Violet’s individual loneliness, the records and birds now signify the couple’s newfound togetherness.

☛☛ Somebody in the house across the alley put a record on and the music floated into us through the open window. Mr. Trace moved his head to the rhythm and his wife snapped her fingers in time. She did a little step in front of him and he smiled. By and by they were dancing. Funny, like old people do, and I laughed for real. Not because of how funny they looked. Something in it made me feel I shouldn’t be there. Shouldn’t be looking at them doing that.

[...] When they finished and I asked for my sweater, Mrs. Trace said, ‘Come back anytime. I want to do your hair for you anyway. Free. Your ends need clipping.’

Mr. Trace sat down and stretched. ‘This place needs birds.’

**Related Characters:** Violet Trace, Joe Trace, Felice (speaker), The Narrator, Dorcas

**Related Themes:**   

**Related Symbols:**  

**Page Number:** 214

### Explanation and Analysis

In this vital passage, Felice’s newfound friendship with the Trace couple allows her to witness a moment of surprising intimacy between the two of them. This scene is important because it inverts the meaning, nearly simultaneously, of the novel’s two most prominent symbols. First, a jazz record plays, allowing Joe and Violet to dance together. So while records were long associated, in the narrator’s mind, with predictable, inevitable doom, now the jazz music allows Joe and Violet to behave counter to the neighborhood’s assumptions about them, finding something intimate and private in their dance. As Felice watches the Traces move their bodies in time to the rhythm, she admires how “for real” they are in their care for each other, how unpredictable they are in their “little steps.”

And it is only fitting, then, that the bird symbolism now changes its meaning as well. At the beginning of the narrative, when Violet unleashed her parrot after Dorcas’ funeral, the narrator saw it as a metaphor for Violet and Joe’s struggles with unrequited love. But now, as Joe and Violet engage in this reciprocal dance—so directed towards each other that it makes Felice feel she “shouldn’t be there”—Joe decides that the couple’s home “needs birds”

## Chapter 10 Quotes

☛☛ So I missed it altogether. I was sure one would kill the other. I waited for it so I could describe it. I was so sure it would happen. That the past was an abused record with no choice but to repeat itself at the crack and no power on earth could lift the arm that held the needle. I was so sure, and they danced and walked all over me. Busy, they were, busy being original, complicated, changeable—human, I guess you’d say, while I was the predictable one, confused in my solitude into arrogance, thinking my space, my view, was the only one that was or that mattered. I got so aroused while meddling, well finger-shaping, I overreached and missed the obvious.

**Related Characters:** The Narrator (speaker), Violet Trace, Joe Trace, Felice, Golden Gray

**Related Themes:**    

**Related Symbols:** 

**Page Number:** 220

### Explanation and Analysis

Now, as the narrator brings her story to its conclusion, she has to admit that she has been incorrect about her predictions; after all, she initially expected that Joe and Violet’s friendship with Felice would lead to yet another shooting, not a found family of sorts. The narrator’s frustration in this moment echoes her earlier angst in the scenes with Golden Gray, when she lamented that she had been “careless and stupid,” “infuriate[d]” to “discover (again) how unreliable” she could be. And the narrator explains her own trustworthiness even more clearly here: she has lost the plot precisely because she has been “waiting” for it so desperately, wanting to “describe” these people rather than engage with them. The almost sexual “arous[al]” that the narrator feels while gossiping has clouded her judgment; even as she tries to shape the narrative for her readers, her characters have slipped out of her control.

It is also important to note the distinction the narrator draws here between the taped music on a record and the live music that Violet and Joe “danced and walked” to. A record goes around and around on its track, “with no choice but to repeat itself”; the narrator has used this pattern as a metaphor for the way that people’s pasts (their childhoods,

their relationships with their parents) impact their futures. But the novel has shown that Joe and Violet are much more like live jazz, “original, complicated, changeable—human.” In fact, this is almost the exact same language Morrison herself uses to describe “the essence of the Jazz Age,” which she says is defined as “improvisation, originality, change.”

On the one hand, then, this vital passage demonstrates the impossibility of predicting human behavior. But on the other hand, the narrator’s pain here also demonstrates the importance of engaging with community. The narrator feels she missed things because she “confused [her] solitude into arrogance,” sitting behind her window and making judgments rather than going into the city streets. Maybe if she, too, had “walked and danced,” the narrator seems to reflect, she would not have “missed the obvious.”

💬 But I can’t say that aloud; I can’t tell anyone that I have been waiting for this all my life and that being chosen to wait is the reason I can. If I were able I’d say it. Say make me, remake me. You are free to do it and I am free to let you because look, look. Look where your hands are. Now.

**Related Characters:** The Narrator (speaker), Violet Trace, Joe Trace

**Related Themes:**



**Page Number:** 229

### Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, the very final moment of the novel, the narrator slips into perhaps her most musical prose yet, dreaming of an intimacy like the one Violet and Joe share with each other. In imagining this closeness, the narrator sees the opportunity for invention (“make me, remake me”), taking on an optimism that Morrison suggests is essential to jazz music. She also sees liberation (“you are free to do it and I am free to let you”), a counter to the white supremacy and internalized racism that has caused characters such pain throughout the story. And the narrator, always focused on predicting the future, at last is able to be present, breaking into bodily sensation and emphasizing the “now.”

Perhaps most touchingly, the fragmentary nature of sentences like “look where your hands are”—and the physical intimacy they imply—suggest that the narrator is already beginning to learn the lessons of jazz (and *Jazz*). After all, in some ways, each reader has become the partner the narrator seems to be searching for; she might not be able to say her most private thoughts “aloud,” but at least she can put them in writing and then share them with the reader.



## SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

## CHAPTER 1

"Sth," an unnamed narrator gossips, "I know that woman." This narrator is talking about Violet and her husband Joe Trace, a middle-aged couple who live on Lenox Avenue in New York City and keep **birds**. Joe fell in love with a much younger woman, then he killed her in a moment of jealousy; later, Violet went to her husband's mistress's funeral just to stab the already-dead girl in her coffin. After the funeral, Violet went home and set all her birds free, even the parrot who used to chirp "I love you" all day long.

Even though Joe killed the girl, he still cried every day in mourning for her. For her part, Violet—not shamed even after her outburst at the funeral—took up with another man, sleeping with him in front of Joe. The narrator reflects that though Violet was thin and pretty, Joe paid no attention to her, no matter how jealous she tried to make him or how many meals she cooked. Eventually, Violet gave up trying, and she "decided to love—well, find out about—the eighteen-year-old whose creamy face she tried to cut open even though nothing would have come out but straw."

At first, Violet knew almost nothing about the girl (later revealed to be named Dorcas). To learn more, Violet asked Malvonne, the neighbor who had rented Joe her apartment as a "love nest"; she also asked at the "legally licensed beauty parlor" Dorcas used to frequent. When that wasn't enough, Violet asked Dorcas's former schoolteachers and the girl's dignified old aunt. Violet even learned the girl's favorite dance steps, and she would do them herself, much to the horror of everyone around her (including Joe and her now-ex-boyfriend).

One day, Dorcas's aunt Alice gives Violet a picture of the dead girl, and Violet sets it on the mantle so she and Joe can both look at it whenever they want. But though the narrator assumes this picture on the mantle makes Violet's apartment feel like a funeral home, things change that spring when Violet meets a girl Dorcas's age. "That's how that scandalizing threesome on Lenox Avenue began," the narrator reflects. "What turned out different was who shot whom."

*This opening line ("sth, I know that woman") immediately sets up several of the novel's most essential themes. First, the musical sound of the first word, "sth," links the form of the novel to the jazz music that inspired it. Second, the narrator's confidence in "knowing" Violet just from gossip and observation sets her up for possible disappointment later, if her predictions about Violet and Joe fail to come true. And finally, the parrot with its unreciprocated "I love you" acts as a mirror for the unrequited love between Joe, Violet, and the girl Joe fell in love with.*



*It is important to note the story's unusual structure: rather than keeping readers in suspense about the juiciest plot points, Morrison reveals most of the most essential twists right away. In doing so, she suggests that Violet's quest to "find out about" the girl Joe killed is where the real surprise lies, not in the sordid details of Joe's affair. The mention of the girl's youth (she appears to Violet as "the eighteen-year-old" with the "creamy face") also hints at possible maternal feelings that Violet has towards this girl.*



*Like the narrator, Violet is obsessed with learning everything she can about Dorcas and the circumstances that tied her to Joe. But unlike the narrator, Violet intuits that understanding somebody cannot come merely from observing them; instead, she feels determined to sit in the places where Dorcas sat, to dance the steps Dorcas used to dance. In giving so much of herself to Dorcas, however, Violet seems to be losing touch with her own identity.*



*In making this vague, frightening threat about another shooting in relation to the "scandalizing threesome," the narrator creates a sense of foreboding for her readers, framing Violet and Joe as fated for doom.*



The narrator announces that she is “crazy about this city.” She loves the tall buildings and the fancy stone architecture; to her, the city feels like it’s always “1926 when all the wars are over and there will never be another one.” Everybody is always “thinking future thoughts” in New York City, and there is always music, always people falling in love. And though there is a great deal of anti-Black racism, there are more Black nurses and doctors and clerks than ever.

*From the mentions of Lenox Avenue and the descriptions of the architecture, it is clear that the novel is set in Harlem, New York City at the height of the Harlem Renaissance (an era where Black art, music, literature, and theater flourished). Though the narrator sees Harlem as a kind of oasis, her description is not altogether hopeful. Instead, the story notes just how much racial discrimination and violence still persists—and though the narrator is excited about the “future,” contemporary readers know that the post-World War I era the narrator describes is merely the prelude to the even bloodier World War II.*



As long as you are careful in the city, the narrator explains, none of its criminality or chaos can hurt you. For her part, the narrator mostly stays inside, watching city life rather than participating in it. In the first days of 1926, when Violet attacked Dorcas’s funeral, the “doomsayers” saw it is a sign that the year was cursed. But the narrator sees things differently—in New York, she thinks, you have to know “when to love something and when to quit.”

*The narrator has already introduced her audience to her own methods of prediction and gossip, but this passage suggests that there are many different kinds of “doomsayers” in the neighborhood. She’s also very convinced that her advice to know “when to quit” something is the only correct advice, highlighting her self-confidence.*



Though winters are cold in Harlem, the people there adore it. Everyone is neighborly, willing to gossip or lend cooking ingredients. Segregation is still the norm, but in Harlem, anyone of any race can hail a cab or sit in a restaurant. Only Violet and Joe seem removed from this swirl, staying up all night to take turns looking at the picture of the dead Dorcas on their mantle.

*The joy the narrator feels in the simple fact of being able to hail a cab or sit at a restaurant speaks to the otherwise pervasive, deforming nature of racial segregation beyond the Black enclave of 1920s Harlem. Tonally, the narrator’s emphasis on the picture of Dorcas creates a sense of claustrophobia and adds to the dread that the story ascribes to this couple.*



Violet’s apartment used to feel bustling, filled with **birds** and the customers who came to get their hair done for cheap (Violet can’t charge as much as the beauty parlors because she doesn’t have her license). But now the birds are gone, and since the funeral, most of Violet’s clients have started doing their own hair. So Violet has started traveling door-to-door, tending to “women who wake in the afternoon, pour gin in their tea and don’t care what she has done.”

*In the first sentence of the narrative, Violet’s birds appeared to be a symbol of loneliness and unrequited love. But in earlier (pre-Dorcas) times, it is clear that the noisy birds signaled the companionship and business of Violet’s relatively happy life. The reference to “women who wake in the afternoon” suggests that Violet now mostly cuts hair for sex workers.*



As Violet curls her clients’ hair, she talks about what happened between Joe and Dorcas. Sometimes she cries and sometimes her hand slips, and she burns her clients’ heads. These women tip well and listen well, and they advise Violet that “you can’t rival the dead for love.” Violet knows this is true, and that Joe is still in love with Dorcas. Violet also worries that she, too, is “falling in love” with Dorcas, obsessing over her light skin and dark eyes and split ends.

*Though the narrator initially presented Violet as angry rather than distraught, Violet’s shakiness with the hair iron points to the depth of her pain. More importantly, it is crucial to track how Violet’s emotions and affections get confused; her care for Joe now seems to be partially transferred onto Dorcas, and Violet can no longer tell how or why her feelings originate.*





Now, Violet soaps a client's head, and the narrator wonders if Violet became a hairdresser because of her grandmother, True Belle. True Belle lived in Baltimore and worked for Miss Vera Louise in a fine, fancy house. True Belle spent most of her time washing soft baby curls, and Violet had always loved hearing stories of her grandmother playing with this beautiful blonde hair.

The narrator decides that no one in Harlem should have been surprised by Violet's outburst at the funeral. Years earlier, Violet had suddenly sat down in the middle of the street, and she wouldn't get up even when a policeman came. Finally, Violet had roused herself, dusted herself off, and made it to her next appointment a full hour late.

And it wasn't just the sitting incident—"quiet as it's kept," the narrator has not forgotten the rumors that Violet tried to steal a baby. The story goes that Violet was waiting for an appointment with the Dumfrey women, a wealthy mother-and-daughter duo who tried to hide their country roots. Violet was gossiping with a neighbor, biding time—and then the baby was in her arms. Violet cradled the child and felt a surge of peace, imagining bringing the baby home to Joe. In her joy, Violet then started laughing out loud.

To this day, some people think that loud laugh confirmed that Violet was a baby thief, while others think that the laugh proved she was just holding the baby as a favor. When a crowd gathered to accuse Violet, she defended herself well, calling the claims that she would try to take somebody's baby ridiculous. But every so often, Violet still fondly recalls the warmth in her veins when she held that baby. In her worst moments, Violet imagines moving that warmth around in her body, "distributed, if need be, into places dark as the bottom of the well."

Joe never learns of these "cracks" in Violet's behavior, though sometimes his best friends Stuck and Gistan imply things. Violet used to be so reliable, calmly deciding to marry Joe, come to New York, and start a hairdressing business. But the cracks had started to appear years earlier, including once when Violet noticed Joe looking too long at a pretty girl in a drug store. And Joe had felt her silences, how mostly Violet spoke to her **parrot** who said, "I love you" in response.

*Joe's affair has muddled Violet's feelings in one way, but True Belle's stories of the soft baby curls also demonstrate how racism and colorism have impacted Violet's affections.*



*For the first time, it appears that Violet's pain might not stem only—or even primarily—from Joe's betrayal with Dorcas. Instead, the fact that Violet sat down in the street speaks to both her stubbornness and a deep sense of malaise, or meaninglessness.*



*The narrative will strongly hint that Violet is menopausal, so her desire for a baby is a biological impossibility. Still, Violet's hunger for motherhood adds another layer to her relationships with Dorcas; is this girl Violet's enemy, or a young woman she wants to care for? Interestingly, the phrase "quiet as it's kept" is the opening line of Morrison's debut novel [The Bluest Eye](#), another book interested in how gossip and community can impact private life.*



*The gossiping neighbors here act almost as a jury, trying to decide whether Violet is crazy or misunderstood even as the narrator seems to embark on a similar quest of characterization. Violet's reference to the "bottom of the well" will be important to keep in mind for later. Her complicated feelings about motherhood—and her desire to have a baby—are thus intimately linked with her own childhood loss.*



*Implicitly, the narrator seems to suggest that if someone pays attention to the "cracks"—or irregularities—in the people around them, they can predict how those people will behave. (Though the narrative will later contest this claim). The parrot's unanswered "I love you" to Violet is now even more explicitly a stand-in for Joe's own feelings of loneliness in his marriage.*



## CHAPTER 2

Now, Violet no longer has the routines of caring for the **birds**. And Joe, too, has lost his daily ritual of spending time with Dorcas, though he knows he was losing that intimacy even before he killed Dorcas. Dorcas wanted to dance and go to parties, and Joe had killed her—had “hunted her down”—because he could tell their days together were coming to an end. At night, he spends hours just trying to sear the memory of her into his brain.

Joe cannot remember anything about his life with Violet in Vesper County, Virginia, but he remembers meeting Dorcas with perfect clarity. After seeing her at the drug store, he ran into her again at her aunt Alice Manfred’s house, when he was delivering someone’s Cleopatra beauty products order. Right away, Joe made his interest to Dorcas known: “he did not yearn or pine for the girl, rather he thought about her, and decided.” This courtship was very different than when he met Violet, who Joe feels had chosen him (instead of the other way around).

When Joe and Violet first came up to New York City from Virginia, they were so excited, almost dancing as the train brought them to the skyscrapers. The train attendant came in, telling everyone there was breakfast in the dining car if they wanted it. But much to the attendant’s dismay, almost none of the Black passengers ever went to the dining car, instead eating the food they brought from home.

Waves of Black people had started migrating to New York in the 1870s, escaping violence and poverty in their hometowns. And people were also leaving behind the specter of the war, “betrayed by the commander for whom they had fought like lunatics.” No matter the reason they came, though, most of the country people soon embraced “the City.” No one in New York could tell if they were falling in love with one another or with the “curved stone” of the buildings and the lit-up night sky, “more like the ocean than the ocean itself.”

Joe thinks Violet has forgotten their early days in New York. When Dorcas was still alive, he would tell her about these memories. And he would tell Dorcas things he never told Violet, or anyone: how he waited in the bushes, smelling hibiscus, for a wild woman in the woods to give him some sign that she was indeed his mother. Joe would have felt so ashamed and so happy to just get this moment of recognition. Dorcas, too, would cry, remembering waking up at a friend’s house to the smell of something burning. Dorcas had run home and begged her mother to rescue her dolls, but neither Dorcas’s dolls nor her mother had made it out of the house.

*Though Joe’s murder of Dorcas is common knowledge in the novel, this is the first time that the narrator gives any insight into his motivations. Joe’s desperate desire to possess Dorcas, to “hunt her down” and catch her, is disturbing here, but will eventually be explained in more detail.*



*As will become clear over the course of the story, Joe has had very little agency in his own life: even his marriage to Violet felt almost forced upon him, led by Violet’s own confidence and decisiveness. So Dorcas represents Joe’s feeling of control over his destiny, a novelty in his life thus far.*



*The fact that very few Black passengers enter the dining car, even after it has stopped being legally segregated, speaks to the diffuse, almost omnipresent legacies of racism and slavery.*



*The Reconstruction era that followed the Civil War entailed some of the worst anti-Black violence in American history (with the rise of the Ku Klux Klan, lynching, and widespread arson). Then, the fact that Black soldiers returned from having served the U.S. in deadly combat in World War I to find even more violence and segregation on the home front added insult to injury. On a different note, the imagery of “curved stone” and the lit-up night sky paints the city as feminine and romantic, with an almost sexual attraction.*



*Both Joe and Dorcas were deprived of their parents at an early age (Joe because his “wild” mother abandoned him, and Dorcas because her parents were seemingly killed). A big part of their time together, therefore, involves them bonding over this shared loss (and particularly over how much they miss their mothers). The almost childlike way that Joe and Dorcas talk about this trauma suggests that both of them have been in some way stunted by it; the fact that Joe has never shared any of this pain with Violet testifies to the ways in which the couple struggles to find true intimacy.*



Dorcas and Joe would comfort each other, and then they would have sex, laughing and shouting and pampering each other with Joe's Cleopatra products. Before they left Malvonne's small apartment, Dorcas heading home to her aunt Alice Manfred and Joe returning to Violet, Dorcas would make Joe promise to take her to Mexico, even though it was loud there.

Malvonne works the night shift as a cleaning lady in a big office building, but she is more interested in the "neighborhood people," especially her nephew Sweetness. Sweetness has now changed his name and headed west somewhere, but Malvonne still goes through the mail he used to collect. Sometimes, she gets involved in the letters she reads, adding an extra stamp in the hopes that the messages will reach their intended audiences more quickly.

One day, Joe arrives to Malvonne's small apartment with a proposition: he will give her two dollars a month, and she will let him bring a girl to her apartment while she is at work. Malvonne hesitates at first, protesting that she doesn't want to betray Violet. But Joe is adamant that he won't involve Malvonne at all, and that he has never done anything like this before. Besides, he complains, Violet pays more attention to her **birds** than she does to him.

Malvonne agrees, and Joe becomes what the narrator calls a "Thursday man," seeking not the intensity of the weekend but the "satisfaction pure and deep" of this middle of the week. The narrator reflects that there are always Thursday men walking around the city, filled with so much energy that it can change the air around them, "from freezing to hot to cool."

## CHAPTER 3

It is July of 1917, and Alice Manfred is watching a march on Fifth Avenue. Alice has felt fear all of her life: first in Illinois, then in Massachusetts, and now on Fifth Avenue, "where salesmen touched her [...] as though she were part of the goods they had condescended to sell her," "where she, a woman of fifty and independent means, had no surname." The silent, unblinking marchers, all of them Black and beating drums, help Alice feel pain and rage instead of fear.

*Mexico will later be revealed to be the name of a night club, but the confusion about the word "Mexico" is intentional—everything about Joe and Dorcas's affair feels foreign and hazy, as if at any moment they could be going to listen to jazz or to elope to a new, tropical country.*



*This strange digression into Malvonne's story suggests just how much the people in Harlem invest in others' lives (it also nods to the novel's non-linear, jazz-like structure). Many scholars wonder if Malvonne is actually the narrator herself, as both get so caught up in the gossip of the "neighborhood people." Other experts, however, believe that the narrator is a more amorphous, less literal figure than Malvonne.*



*On the one hand, Malvonne's involvement in Joe's affair might make Violet feel that she was betrayed not only by her husband but by her whole community. On the other hand, Joe feels that he is justified in his affair, as he has always tried to be loyal—until Violet started ignoring him entirely, choosing instead to commune with her birds.*



*The novel lapses almost into poetry here, its phrases ("pure and deep," "from freezing to hot to cool") expertly mimicking the phrases of jazz music. Joe's "Thursday," peaceful satisfaction stands in stark contrast to Dorcas's "weekend" desires, which the novel will describe in more detail later.*



*The march Alice is watching here is known as the 1917 NAACP Silent Protest Parade, a response to white violence all over the country: lynchings in Memphis and Waco, and most horrifically, the East St. Louis Massacre. Implicitly, Alice's memories of the dehumanizing treatment she faces in her everyday, New York City life shows just how intimately the quotidian experience of racism and segregation—even in northern states like Illinois and Massachusetts and New York—is related to the deadly violence the marchers are protesting.*



Watching this march focuses Alice, especially when it comes to the orphaned little girl newly in her care. Alice now teaches her charge not to acknowledge the cruel things white people say, to never show her hair or wear risqué clothes. And when Alice gets jobs sewing and leaves the girl, Dorcas, to be babysat by some religious ladies, she agrees with the babysitters that red lipstick and “lowdown music” (jazz) are signs of society’s “Imminent Demise.”

Everyone Alice knows is trying to make sense of the East St. Louis riots that killed Dorcas’s mother (Alice’s sister) and father. Some people say the riots were started by disgruntled Black veterans, fed up with violence that’s worse at home than in Europe. Others believe it was white people, terrified by a new wave of Black prosperity. But Alice, whose brother-in-law owned a pool hall and was just on an everyday bus ride home when he was beaten to death, blames the music. “It made you do unwise disorderly things,” she thinks.

As Dorcas gets older, Alice cherishes the strengthening memory of the march. Alice also tries to dismiss the music she hears, which church pamphlets tell her is “wasn’t real music—just colored folks’ stuff,” but which she thinks might conceal some “appetite,” some “complicated anger.” The narrator reflects that try as she might, Alice will never totally be able to separate the music she claims to loathe from those pounding Fifth Avenue drums.

Dorcas, however, never tries to restrain herself from the “life-below-the-sash” her aunt Alice so loathes. The narrator muses that a spark from the fire that burned Dorcas’s house down must have lodged in the girl’s throat, making her bold. At her parents’ funeral, Dorcas thought not of the mother and father she was losing but of the dolls that had burned to a crisp, who would never have a funeral of their own.

Having seen all of this at such a young age, Dorcas is never anything but “bold.” She is fascinated by stories of women who travel hundreds of miles for the men they love; she treasures hearing about a woman who suffered paralysis after her fiancée left her at the altar. The narrator empathizes with Dorcas’s desire for men. By 17, Dorcas spends all her time wondering what it would be like to have sex, hoping her lovers won’t laugh at the way her naked body looks.

Now, readers learn that Dorcas winds up in Alice’s care precisely because of this horrific violence. The strict rules Alice enforces onto her niece result from Alice’s fear that any behavior from Dorcas that is not in line with white expectations could lead her niece to meet with emotional or bodily harm. This kind of thinking is often known as “respectability politics,” and the novel is both sympathetic and critical of it.



The blame Alice places on jazz, a style of music pioneered and popularized by Black artists, suggests that she has internalized some of the prejudice she faces day in and day out. Though there is clearly a barbarism to the violence that killed Alice’s family, she attributes this not to a white desire to retain economic and political power but to the unpredictability of “unwise disorderly” jazz.



Alice prefers the order of the march to the “disorder” of the jazz music, with its “appetite” for change and “the future” (in the narrator’s words). But as the story now makes clear, the hunger in jazz is deeply linked to—and inseparable from—the demands implied by the marchers walking down Fifth Avenue.



In many ways, Dorcas’s life seems to speak to the way that racial violence and the pleasurable wildness of jazz are linked. Haunted by the unbearable tragedy of her parents’ death, Dorcas throws herself into carnal delight, embracing parties, outré clothing, and romantic/sexual relationships.



Over and over again, the novel will assert that people’s adult behavior in romantic relationships is linked to their childhood experiences with their parents (or parental figures). Here, Dorcas’s need to be loved and desired perhaps reflects the absence she felt after her parents were both murdered.



One night, when Dorcas is 16, she sneaks out to a party with her best friend Felice. Being with Felice, whose skin is darker and whose hair is oily, always makes Dorcas feel confident. And tonight, as they take in the **records** and the alcohol and the dancing, both girls are filled with reckless glee. Dorcas has spent all day trying to make the conservative clothes she has at home look suitable for this evening.

As the lights dim, Dorcas notices two brothers dancing in the center of the room, commanding all the attention. Dorcas sees the boys whispering about her, and she feels her stomach flip, the sensation that always tells her she has a crush. But before she can approach, Dorcas sees one of the brothers wrinkle his nose at her, and she becomes convinced that “the body she inhabits is unworthy.” The narrator understands, then, why Joe Trace would be appealing to a girl who felt both such “hunger” and such rejection.

For Joe, running into Dorcas again was merely a happy accident. He had decided to make an early delivery of some of his beauty products, interrupting a luncheon for the Civic Daughters. All the women there were happy to see Joe, flirting with him and feeding him lunch even though he knew it would ruin his appetite for Violet’s fattening cooking. Joe was used to this flirtation, to the way women lit up when they heard his rural intonations—so the narrator has never understood what made Dorcas, and that day, different.

The narrator wonders if Alice had a premonition that Joe would fall for her niece Dorcas. But probably not—Alice is too busy reading newspapers cover to cover to pay attention to what happens on the street, to learn how people really behave. The narrator thinks that if Alice had come out more, she might have seen Joe’s shots coming. Most of all, the narrator marvels that “the woman who avoided the streets let into her living room the woman who sat down in one.”

Near the end of March, Alice is knitting and thinking about the “impunity” Joe Trace had to kill her niece. Joe seemed like a sweet, neighborly man, someone whom women could let into their homes and trust. The fact that Joe turned out to be dangerous, then, destroyed Alice; “the brutalizing men and their brutal women,” she learned, “were not just out there, they were in her block, her house.” Now, she spends her time reading newspapers, learning every day of some new violence against women.

*The jazz records at this party are salient, as they represent both the unpredictability of the jazz genre and the repetition of recorded music. Dorcas’ description of Felice once more shows how racism and colorism subtly inflect friendships and day-to-day life: Dorcas believes she’s just a little bit better than her friend because her skin is lighter than Felice’s.*



*One of Morrison’s trademarks as a writer is her ability to highlight how small, seemingly forgettable moments can shape one’s entire future or sense of self. Here, Dorcas’s rejection (based only on her appearance) by these two handsome young men makes her suddenly, desperately crave the affection and devotion Joe Trace might offer her.*



*For the first time, the narrator seems forced to admit that she is unable to completely predict why certain interactions or decisions occur. Violet’s fattening cooking hints at Violet’s discomfort in her own body—rather than accepting herself as she is, Violet wants to look different and curvier.*



*Though the narrator critiques Alice Manfred for focusing only on newspapers and not on the world around her, the narrator is guilty of that exact same habit (as she later admits to watching life from her window rather than participating in it). Violet’s willingness to experience life firsthand—to be in “the streets”—forms a complement to Alice’s caution.*



*Like the narrator, Alice once felt that reading and talking about the news would allow her to distinguish between “the brutalizing men” and the safe ones. But Joe’s murder of Dorcas proves that is no longer true. The violence against women that Alice reads about reminds readers just how intersectional prejudice and harm is—if women are vulnerable in general, then Black women like Alice and Dorcas face danger from many aspects of their identities.*





At first, Alice had thought Dorcas, and most women, were defenseless. But that changed when Violet Trace showed up at Alice's door, filling Alice with fear. Alice at first turned Violet away, but after Violet (or "Violent," as people called her now) was gone, Alice found herself newly angry, more furious at Violet than afraid of her. Without realizing it, Alice began to wait for Violet to return.

Alice reflects that she spent most of her life restraining herself, taught by her parents to avoid pregnancy before marriage at all costs. But while Alice feels she has chosen "surrender," and forced Dorcas to do the same, they are other women like Violet who have chosen war. With some measure of pride, Alice thinks about the Black women she knows who have hurt men. "Black women were armed," she muses, "black women were dangerous and the less money they had the deadlier the weapon they chose."

Besides, Alice knows there is more than one way of being armed. Some women found protection in God, who they felt was angry and judgmental, taking revenge on their behalf. Other women hoarded money and houses, hoping wealth would keep them safe. So maybe it is unsurprising that Alice feels comfortable with Violet, who holds a knife and leaves notes under her door for months, pleading to be let in. One day in February, Alice finally decides to open her door.

As soon as Violet walks into Alice's apartment for the first time, she heads straight to the picture of Dorcas. Alice's nervousness is evident, but Violet assures her that she has nothing to fear. Whenever Alice presses Violet for answers or insight, Violet seems just as confused as Alice herself was. Indeed, Violet seems overwhelmed just being there, complaining of a headache and asking to lie down.

The next time Violet comes, Alice asks if Joe was violent to her. Violet explains that he wasn't: before Dorcas, Joe had never hurt anything but the animals he used to hunt. But Alice doesn't want to hear Violet describe her history with Joe, so she sends her away. The next day, Alice, bothered by Violet's shabby appearance, offers to repair a tear in Violet's dress. Violet never takes off her hat during these visits.

Alice, remembering what it felt like to iron men's clothing, is now ironing every scrap of fabric in her house. She has started to look forward to Violet's visits, though these visits make her angry. But Alice likes how she is when she is with Violet—less polite and nervous, ready to joke and unwilling to apologize.

*Previously, Alice felt her fear turned into rage by the marchers on Fifth Avenue; now, her brief encounter with Violet creates a similarly energizing effect. The slippage between the words Violet and "Violent" again demonstrates how the novel uses wordplay to echo the improvisational tones of jazz music.*



*Alice loathes and condemns the fact that Violet showed up at Dorcas's funeral with a knife. But privately, Alice also admires that Violet found a way to be "dangerous" instead of "surrendering" to societal danger, claiming some of the agency that Alice feels she has herself never really had.*



*It is important to track the passage of time—the story begins with death in the dead of winter, but Alice and Violet's friendship starts in February, a moment of symbolic and literal thaw. The seasons are at once cyclical and changeable, just like the emerging bond between these two women.*



*The narrator seems determined to offer neat, straightforward explanations for even confusing behavior (like the fact that Alice lets the woman who stabbed her niece into her apartment). But Alice and Violet are comfortable with uncertainty and contradiction.*



*Violet's comments about Joe here once more ties his feelings for Dorcas to his years hunting in childhood, suggesting again that youthful experience impacts adult behavior. Alice's decision to mend Violet's dress hints at the almost maternal cast that their relationship takes on.*



*It seems that some of Violet's bravery is rubbing off on Alice; for the first time, Alice is comfortable enough to mock or challenge the inequities in her life rather than trying to ignore or contort herself for them.*



As Alice makes tea, Violet tells stories about the sex workers whose hair she cuts. Sometimes, Alice wonders how anyone could kill anyone else; Violet counters that women should fight for their men. Alice does not say this to Violet, but she has her own memories of an unfaithful husband, now buried in Springfield, Massachusetts. For seven months after her husband left her, Alice had thirsted for blood, imagining violent ends for all of his mistresses.

At the end of those seven months, however, Alice's husband had died; she had planned his funeral. One of the mistresses attended, and Alice felt she wasn't allowed to say a word about any of her pain. Thinking of all this, Alice slams her iron down and turns to Violet. "You don't know what loss is," Alice says.

*Now, Violet emerges as an even more concrete mirror for Alice, as Alice, too, has been betrayed by a husband. Alice's fantasies of violence complicate the tidy divide the narrator has tried to draw between the two women, a reminder that characterization is never as easy as the archetypes created by gossip.*



*The sheer degree of loss Alice has experienced is staggering: her sister was killed, her husband left her and then died, and now her only family—Dorcas—has also been murdered. But in some ways, Alice feels she "knows" most of all because she has had to suffer in silence, losing not only the people she loved but the ability to talk about those losses with others.*



## CHAPTER 4

After tea with Alice Manfred, Violet heads to the drug store, where—still desperate to return to her youthful curviness—she gets a malted milk. As she sips, Violet reflects on the difference between herself and "that Violet," the other Violet who sees danger and anger where the regular Violet feels lonely or protective. *That* Violet was the one who had found Dorcas's funeral, fighting off the usher boys and stabbing Dorcas before the regular Violet even knew she was holding the knife.

Though it went against all of the good manners their elders had taught them, those usher boys had fought Violet off, not knowing if she intended just one stabbing or more. As the ushers dragged Violet away, kicking and growling, she was amazed to realize that *that* Violet still possessed all the power and toughness she'd had back in Virginia.

In the days after the funeral, when Joe did not come home, Violet found her **parrot's** repeated "I love you" unbearable. But the Violet drinking a malted wishes *that* Violet hadn't let the parrot go. Maybe he had been snatched by a passer-by, Violet thinks. Or maybe the bird had gotten the message—"that she said, 'My parrot,' and he said, 'Love you,' and she had never said it back"—and just decided to fly away.

*Many of the details in this passage show just how fractured and dissociated Violet's identity is. Violet cannot reconcile the angry, paranoid part of herself with the maternal, romantic aspects, separating herself into two different figures (Violet and "that Violet"). And touchingly, Violet cannot even seem to accept the contours of her own body, forcing herself to eat fattening foods in the hopes of changing even her physical shape.*



*Though Violet at first seems to loathe this other, dissociated version of herself, she also feels some measure of pride that that Violet has the strength and vivacity of her youth (the very thing she is trying to regain by drinking the malted milk).*



*Violet's treatment of the parrot echoes her treatment of Joe, as their marriage has similarly turned into a series of routines and unanswered statements of affection. But while that Violet seems committed to letting both bird and husband vanish, the main Violet misses the bird—and implicitly misses her husband, too.*



Violet orders another malted, though her stomach hurts from the last one. As she sips, Violet wonders what magazines Dorcas read, what rituals she and Joe shared. Violet begins to picture the gifts Joe bought Dorcas with his prizes from Cleopatra beauty products, including the lacy underwear Dorcas wore as they slept together or went out to jazz clubs.

The more Violet pictures Joe and Dorcas, the surer she becomes that “*that Violet is me!*” Violet recalls how sure she was about Joe, how proud and possessive she was of him. But she also wonders if Joe ever loved her and confided in her, or if he was always searching for Dorcas, wanting her even before he met her. In her own way, Violet has to admit that she was always searching for someone, too: the golden-haired boy True Belle used to talk about.

“I got quiet,” Violet realizes, “because the things I couldn’t say were coming out of my mouth anyhow.” Violet plays with her drink, which makes her think of her mother, drinking coffee after all of their belongings were taken from them. When her mother wouldn’t move from her chair, the repo men tipped the chair over and her mother fell on the floor, with Violet and all her siblings watching.

For days after that, as the family huddled in an abandoned shack, Violet’s mother Rose Dear would not say a word. It was only through a neighbor, heading north like all the others, that word of Rose Dear’s plight reached Violet’s grandmother, True Belle. True Belle returned right away, with 10 dollars sewn into her skirt, and she helped the family get back on its feet, earning Violet’s abiding adoration.

One day, four years after True Belle returned, Rose Dear threw herself into a well. Two weeks after that, Violet’s father returned home with gifts for the children and a silk embroidered pillow for his wife. When he heard that Rose Dear was dead, the only thing Violet’s father could do was say “oh, damn.” Ten days later, he was back on the road, working secretly with the Readjuster Party (which aimed to secure voting rights for Black people).

*Violet’s remove from herself now takes on physically painful dimensions, as she pushes her body to gain curves it does not want to hold. Violet’s obsessiveness with Dorcas’s life, her likes and habits and dislikes, forms a funhouse mirror to the narrator’s obsession with Violet and Joe.*



*Interestingly, just at the moment when Violet seems most desperate to get away from herself, she chooses to reintegrate these two facets of her personality. Both Violets have always been searching for someone they barely knew yet envied, whether it was the younger Dorcas or the lighter-skinned boy mentioned here. And now, by victoriously putting these two parts of herself together (“that Violet is me!”), Violet is able to extend some new sympathy to Joe, acknowledging that he, too, has been shaped and hurt by the painful events of his youth.*



*Presumably, some of the things Violet wants to say are references to this childhood trauma with her mother, so gruesome—and so grounded in white efforts to deprive and dispossess Black people—that it feels unspeakable. Therefore, though Joe has seen Violet’s silence as a sign of her lack of care, this passage reframes it as one of the only possible responses to a life of hardship and prejudice.*



*Though Violet will later express a desire to avoid her mother’s fate (and to spare any of her own potential children from the suffering she herself went through), she also uneasily recognizes how her own life and silence have begun to parallel Rose Dear’s.*



*The irony of Violet’s father’s return, just one week after Rose Dear’s suicide, underscores just how impossible it is to predict or plan for the twists and turns of life. The fact that Violet’s father works for the Readjuster Party, advocating for Black political power, likely explains why anxious white people would target their home for repossession.*



For her siblings, Violet's father was a symbol of hope, a promise that any day could suddenly be filled with excitement. But Violet could never forget how it felt to see Rose Dear in that narrow, dark well. Violet wonders what motivated her mother to make the leap: was it the memory of that day with the coffee cup, or the news of white violence, or just the knowledge that her children were at last safe with True Belle? Whatever the reason, though, Violet's memories of her mother make her vow to never have children.

*Violet's decision to remain childless now takes on a new cast, as it is clear this choice is rooted in her own pain (even though the memory of holding a baby helps her cope, temporarily, with her grief at her mother's death). The young Violet's inability to predict her own later-in-life desire for motherhood then mimics her inability to understand what motivated Rose Dear to jump at such a seemingly random time. Unlike the narrator, assigning neat cause and effect, the circumstances of Violet's life have forced her to accept that there are rarely neat inflection points in people's minds.*



It was memories of Rose Dear in the well that made Violet want to leave her childhood home and pick cotton in Palestine, Virginia. At first, Violet struggled with the rough work, and she thought about going home. But one night, while she was sleeping under a walnut tree, Violet was surprised by a man who rolled out of the tree's branches, onto the ground.

*On the one hand, the novel pushes back against the idea that there is such a thing as fate or destiny. But on the other hand, the tragedy of Rose Dear's death leads Violet right to Palestine, and then—under this walnut tree—to the man who will become her husband.*



Right away, Violet teases the man about sleeping in a tree and he teases her about her snarky attitude. The two talk all night, and Violet learns that the man's name is Joe. By the time the sun comes up, Violet has decided that this is the man she wants to spend her life with ("claimed him"). And because Violet met Joe in the middle of the night, she felt that "nighttime was never the same for her," as she could never again be haunted by thoughts of Rose Dear in the well.

*The narrative frequently suggests that childhood, familial experience impacts adult, romantic decision-making, but that link is perhaps clearest and most direct here (in Violet's decision to "claim" Joe so as to escape the difficulty of "nighttime" memories). Violet's memories of having agency in this relationship sheds new light on Joe's feelings that he did not really feel in control of the decision to tie his life to Violet's.*



In the morning, Violet and Joe vowed to meet each other near the tree again. From then on, Violet thought only of Joe's two different color eyes, his strong jawline and chest. Violet moved in with a nearby family, doing everything she could to see Joe whenever possible. And though Joe loved the woods he was raised in, he surprised his friends when, 10 years later, he agreed to move with Violet to Baltimore, to the city True Belle had described.

*Previously, Joe and Violet have seemed removed, frustrated and a little disgusted by the other's appearance and behavior. But these memories suggest that once, Violet was passionately, almost obsessively, interested in Joe (fixating on him as she now fixates on Dorcas).*



But before they could move to Baltimore, Joe decided he wanted to go to New York City instead. Violet never quite knew what motivated the decision, other than that Booker T. Washington was eating chicken in the President's house, and Joe seemed filled with a newfound confidence. Violet was nervous to go to New York, but as soon as she got there she knew she would love "the City" forever.

*In 1901, Black civil rights activist and educator Booker T. Washington was invited to dine with President Theodore Roosevelt in the White House. To Joe, even this small gesture towards racial equality made him feel hopeful and energized, giving him the push he needed to go north (or at least, that is Violet's theory of what happened; Joe himself later tells the story differently).*



Joe didn't want children either, so he wasn't sad about Violet's three miscarriages. But as Violet aged, she thought more and more about babies. Now, Violet sometimes gets so distracted by thoughts of cradling a child that she sings her client's curls. And as Violet, menopausal, stares at the picture of Dorcas, she asks herself if Dorcas was "the woman who took the man, or the daughter who fled her womb?" Violet even considers what might have happened had her aborted baby survived the castor oil and soap she drank—had the imagined child "braved [...] mammy's urgent fists, she might have had the best-dressed hair in the city."

Today, just before she came to get her malted, Violet told Alice that she could have loved Dorcas like a daughter, had they met in a different context. At the same time, though, Violet still wonders what Joe saw in Dorcas—was it her light skin? Her wavy hair? Alice hates this line of questioning, and she insists that Violet is too old to think this way. Laughing, Violet wonders aloud if they will ever feel like grown-ups; privately, she wonders if this was the place her mother got to before giving up.

Alice, having noticed the torn lining in Violet's coat, gets to work repairing it. As the two women talk about ironing strategies and how they learned to do chores, Alice tells Violet that she thinks Joe will continue to betray her. Even so, Alice thinks Violet should stay with her husband: "you got anything left to you at all to love," Alice advises, "you do it."

Violet feels that to love something is to fight for it, but Alice is not so sure. After all, should Violet be fighting a teenaged girl who lost both her parents in a fire? Alice gets so worked up as she poses this question that she burns right through the cloth she is ironing, making Violet laugh with delight. Alice joins in, laughing so hard that their shoulders shake.

Now, having finished her malted, Violet leaves the drugstore, chuckling at the image of herself with the knife at the funeral. Laughing makes Violet think of True Belle, who laughed when she arrived in the aftermath of Rose Dear's collapse. This response might have caused Violet to hate her grandmother, but instead, it gave her strength. "Laughter is serious," Violet realizes. "More complicated, more serious than tears." As she buttons her coat, she notices, "at the same moment that that Violet did, that it was spring."

*At first, Violet seems to have miscarried—but then it becomes clear that she decided to terminate her pregnancies, hoping to spare potential children the pain she herself felt at Rose Dear's collapse. In this essential section, Violet admits that her feelings about Dorcas are muddled, combining her desire for motherhood, her childhood loneliness, and her romantic and sexual envy. Even Violet's hairdressing gets caught in this swirl, as Violet—long critical of Dorcas's split ends—imagines caring for this hair as if it belonged to one of her aborted baby girls.*



*Earlier, Joe's conversations with Dorcas hinted that childhood trauma might stunt adults, making them struggle to feel like the "grown-ups" Violet describes. Now, Violet gives voice to those thoughts, wondering if it is ever possible to shed childhood pain—certainly her mother never did.*



*In this exchange, Alice continues to act like a mother of sorts to Violet, tending her to coat and giving her advice. Fascinatingly, though the narrator earlier emphasized the importance of "knowing when to quit" in love, Alice takes the opposite approach, emphasizing the importance of persistence. After all, isn't Alice, too, finding the only thing "left to [her] to love" through this unlikely friendship with Violet?*



*Continuing to defend a treasured relationship, Alice suggests in her questions here, does not always look like conflict. And accordingly, falling back in love with Joe does not mean Violet needs to tarnish Dorcas's memory.*



*Instead of choosing the stubborn, fearsome path that Violet has been taking, True Belle tried to find humor wherever she could, a moment of pleasure to alleviate the pain. In other words, True Belle understood that people were "complicated," full of contradiction—as emblemized by laughter in grief, for example. Now, Violet is able to similarly link the contradicting versions of herself (buttoning her coat at the same time as "that Violet" does). And in doing so, she moves into a kind of rebirth—spring, at last, has come.*





## CHAPTER 5

The narrator describes springtime in New York City: everybody notices one another more, and the warm air and budding trees fill them with contradictory impulses. Musicians play guitar on the street (“blues man,” the narrator thinks. “Black and bluesman. Blacktherefore blue man”). But this spring, on Lenox Avenue, Joe Trace just sits at home and cries. Violet barely speaks to her husband, but she still washes his handkerchiefs, not wanting them to get too dirty.

The narrator is confident that she knows Joe better than anybody. Joe has a reputation for being kind, but the narrator believes that he is actually vain and proud, ogling women on the street and resenting Violet for all the years he has been faithful to her. In the narrator’s mind, Joe “is bound to the track,” as if he is a **record** going around and around. In other words, the narrator thinks Joe’s affair with Dorcas was fated, though she is still puzzled by some aspects of Joe’s character, like his love of sweet, stale candy canes and peppermints.

Now, Joe tells the story from his perspective. He was born in Vienna, in Vesper County, in 1873, and was taken in by neighbors named Rhoda and Frank Williams, though he was not actually their son. On the first day of school, when the teacher asked Joe his last name, he said that it was Trace (because he had heard Rhoda say that his parents “disappeared without a trace”). The Williams couple had a son, Victory, who was near Joe’s age, and the two became best friends. Every so often, Joe used to boast that his parents would come looking for him, but nobody ever did.

As teenagers, Joe and Victory were mentored by the best hunter in their small town, a man everyone called Hunter’s Hunter. But Joe’s quiet life ended when white supremacists set Vienna on fire, nullifying Black people’s deeds to their properties and destroying the land. So Joe and Victory moved to Palestine, a nearby town, which is where Joe met and married Violet. A decade later, Joe tried to buy a piece of land, but the people who sold it to him ran off with the paper that proved it was his.

In 1906, Joe and Violet took the train to New York City. By the time they got to Harlem, the once-rural area had developed into a prosperous Black community, where Joe and Violet could rent houses that “looked like castles in pictures.” The couple decorated their new apartment with plants and **birds**, and as the cost of living rose, Joe got a job with Cleopatra beauty products to make some extra money (beyond what he made as a waiter).

*By painting Joe’s tears as so at odds with the springtime season, the narrator suggests there is something almost unnatural about the degree to which his grief persists (and perhaps the degree to which Violet continues to tend to him). The link between being “Black” and “therefore blue” once more suggests the harmful prevalence of racial prejudice, and links that discrimination to the sounds of Black music.*



*In this vital passage, the narrator feels that even though she does not have any experiential connection to Joe, merely studying him and gossiping about him has given her deeper knowledge than even Violet possesses. Records now emerge as an important symbol of fate and predictability, as the narrator frames Joe’s life as a recorded song, “bound” to repeat the same “track” forever.*



*Joe’s sense of childhood abandonment is such a big part of his life that it even shapes his last name, Trace. Symbolically, then, the entire “Trace” marriage is founded on the absence Joe struggled with in early childhood. The fact that the story transitions to Joe’s perspective suggests that he is taking his solo, much like a musician in a jazz band might.*



*Now, some parallels between Joe and Violet’s early lives emerge. Both struggled with parents who were absent, and both felt abandoned; both also struggled to retain their homes and sense of normalcy against the tides of white violence. That kind of dispossession (in which white people exploited the legal system in order to take Black people’s land) was a fixture in the post-war South.*



*The luxury and foreignness, to Joe and Violet, of life in Harlem is made clear both in Joe’s description of the “castle”-like homes and in the fancy words (“Cleopatra”) given to clubs and beauty products. In this early stage of the Trace couple’s New York City life, birds and plants represent vitality and bustling, future-oriented promise (though that symbolism will later shift).*



In 1917, Joe was attacked and nearly killed by white men in a riot. Fortunately, Joe recovered, but by 1925, Violet was falling asleep with a doll in her arms and Joe realized how sad his wife was becoming. Shortly after, his affair with Dorcas began. Joe is careful to note that he does not blame Violet for the affair; he only blames himself, both for betraying his wife and for killing Dorcas. "I changed once too often," Joe thinks. "Made myself new one time too many."

Dorcas had acne, but the little hoof-mark scars on her face only endear her more to Joe. Joe reflects on the day he killed her: he had a sense that she was betraying him, so he tracked her like a hunter from borough to borough, just as he had once tracked his mother back in Vesper County. Joe recalls, with pain, his embarrassment and confusion that day, as he visited all of Dorcas's favorite spots in his quest to find her. Though he had a gun with him, it was more his habit from hunting than anything else; Joe did not intend to kill Dorcas, just to touch her.

Several days before Joe shot Dorcas, they had a terrible fight. From then on, Joe saw every young man on the street—"roosters," as he calls them—as competition. Joe knows that if he were younger and had more swagger, he wouldn't have to track Dorcas down; she would "track" him. Again, Joe remembers trying to figure out why Dorcas was making a hair appointment, worrying that she was getting dressed up for someone else. The jazz in the back of the beauty salon confirmed Joe's worst suspicions.

Finally, Joe thinks back to his first date with Dorcas. They had gone to a park, ignoring the dirty looks from white people, and scratched their initials into a rock. Joe recalls all the little presents he bought Dorcas, hoping desperately to ensure that she would visit him again. Dorcas lost her virginity to Joe, but in many ways, having sex with Dorcas felt like a first time for Joe, too. With pleasure and pride, Joe recalls that his affair with Dorcas was his decision alone, just like how he used to find prey in the woods: "I chose you. Nobody gave you to me."

## CHAPTER 6

The narrator boasts that it is "risky" to try and understand anybody's mental state, but that she is determined to try. She notes that Joe likely never knew about True Belle, about what happened after Violet's father joined a party that advocated for Black voting rights and Rose Dear had the house taken away. When True Belle arrived, the family was living off of whatever Violet and her sisters could forage, plus what the neighbors could spare.

*The fact that Joe is not safe from white violence even in Harlem speaks, upsettingly, to the unavoidable nature of white bigotry. Interestingly, while Joe notes Violet's longing for a child as one of the things that creates distance between them, he seems more preoccupied with his own constant invention and reinvention as the source of their divide. Like jazz as a musical genre, Joe seems to be making himself up all the time, a process that once felt invigorating but now exhausts him.*



*Even as Dorcas divides Joe and Violet, she also brings them together, uniting them in their obsessions as they separately visit her favorite spots. Joe's desire to track Dorcas down just like he tracked his mother once more shows how childhood memories of abandonment have influenced Joe's patterns in his grown-up intimate relationships; his desire to touch Dorcas rather than kill her speaks to his longing for connection above all else.*



*Joe wishes that Dorcas would chase after him just as Violet once did, all those years ago under the walnut tree. Ironically, however, Joe seems to resent Violet for her pursuit of him, feeling that she deprived him of some kind of agency in their marriage. So the novel thus questions if he would he feel the same thing if Dorcas tried to "track" him down.*



*This is the second time that Joe has emphasized his feeling of "choosing" Dorcas, an agency that has been denied to him in almost every part of his life. But even as Joe celebrates the power this choice gives him, it also causes him a great deal of pain and insecurity, as can be seen in his desperate desire to maintain Dorcas's affection with little presents and carefully planned dates.*



*As the story spins forward, the narrator seems to feel increasing doubt in her ability to accurately assess what is happening in the brains of those around her (though she is still determined to do so). Structurally, it is vital to note that the story continues to loop back on itself, like a theme with variations—a fitting form for a novel with varied, circular jazz as its subject.*



True Belle stayed with Violet and her siblings for 11 years. During that time, True Belle talked constantly about Vera Louise, the white lady in Baltimore she used to work for, and Golden Gray, Vera Louise's son. Golden was named because of the color of his skin and his hair, which was darker than his mother's but radiantly gold. Both True Belle and Vera Louise devoted all their time to the baby boy.

Vera Louise told everyone that she had come to Baltimore because she hated country life. But the real reason Vera Louise left home was because of her affair with an enslaved Black man. When Vera's parents learned that their daughter was pregnant with Golden Gray, they kicked her out, giving her enough money to sustain herself for the rest of her life.

Vera wanted True Belle to come with her, so True Belle had to leave her own small children. Though True Belle had no choice in the matter, she tried to convince herself that it would be fun to live in a big city, and that Vera might one day pay her enough money to buy her children's freedom. True Belle stayed for 22 years before, after convincing Vera that she was dying, she returned to Vesper County with the wages that Vera had "held in trust" for her since the war ended.

Now, the narrator pictures Golden Gray, as clever and handsome and fancy as True Belle has described him to be. In the narrator's mind, Golden has set off from home in a small carriage, with a stately black horse pulling the way. In the back of the carriage, Golden has brought beautiful items from home. It is August and pouring rain, and Golden's carriage hits a pothole. He gets out to examine the damage.

Suddenly, Golden notices a dark-skinned woman in the woods. When the woman sees him, she runs in terror and hits her head, knocking herself out. Golden is not quite sure if the woman is real or if he has hallucinated her, so he gets off his horse and goes to the place where the woman fell. He holds his breath, worried about catching anything from her, anything that might "touch or penetrate" him.

Golden thinks about leaving the woman in the woods, but he decides against it; he thinks Vera Louise would be shocked by the idea of him bringing the woman into his carriage, and this image pleases him. So Golden hoists the woman and carries her into the carriage, noticing the blood on her neck and hoping she will not die. He wonders what his father, a Black man whom he has never met, will think of his son showing up with this woman in tow. Every time Golden thinks of his father, he uses a slur.

*It is clear from the way True Belle talks about Golden that more than being drawn to him as a person, she is intrigued by the little boy's proximity to whiteness. Given True Belle's age, readers can assume that her work with Vera Louise at least began while Vera's family enslaved True Belle, further complicating the adoration True Belle seems to express for Golden.*



*Though Golden Gray has previously seemed to be white, this plot reveal demonstrates that he is in fact mixed-race (albeit white passing). Again, the fact that most of the story's twists happen in the past suggests that surprise lives more in people's internal logic than in the facts of their lives.*



*Vera Louise styles herself as a modern woman, free of some of the biases that her slaveholder parents possess. Yet Vera's willingness to separate True Belle from her family, and to not actually give her the money she is owed for her work, suggests that Vera is merely dressing up the practices of enslavement with fancier, more progressive language.*



*The narrator seems to have inherited some of True Belle's fascination with Golden Gray, romanticizing him to her readers just as True Belle romanticized him to her granddaughters. And vitally, everything the narrative presents about Golden Gray is filtered through the narrator's conjecture.*



*Though Golden has recently learned of his own Blackness, the racism he has been raised with makes him react to the injured woman with disgust and cruelty. The words "touch or penetrate" hint that there is a specifically sexual undertone to some of Golden's racial anxiety.*



*Tellingly, Golden's decision to help the woman (whose identity is revealed later) is not motivated by any sort of care or moral obligation. Instead, Golden is driven by resentment for his mother, a desire to prove himself, and an anti-Black hatred that shows up in the horrific language he uses to describe even his own father.*



Finally, Golden arrives at the house True Belle has described to him. He ties his horse up front, then goes in and puts his trunk down in the small, tidy cottage. Then, Golden brings the woman from the carriage into the house and lies her down on a cot. To avoid ruining his coat, Golden finds a **green dress** in the house, and he lays it over the woman.

Golden thinks back on the last week. His whole life, he believed that he was white—but now, he has learned from his mother that his father is a Black man named Henry Lestory, the man who owns this house. True Belle had told Golden where to find his father, her final kindness after a lifetime of mending his shirts and sending him homemade treats when he went to boarding school. His whole life, Golden had thought there were only two types of people—white people, and “True Belle’s kind. Black and nothing.”

Golden finds some liquor in the house, and he drinks it. The narrator wonders if she should hate Golden, as he worries about his trunk before he worries about the injured woman (“he checks the fastenings, but not her breath”). But then the narrator decides to forgive him, because she imagines he scrapes the mud off his “Baltimore soles” as he enters the dirt cabin.

Back in the cabin, Golden is still avoiding the woman on the bed. As he struggles to process his conflicting emotions, the narrator reflects that he is shaping a story “to tell his father”; Golden thinks he is being a hero to this young woman, though the narrator knows that he is really a “hypocrite.” The narrator resents that Golden wants to brag about his behavior, but when she thinks about how young he is, that he is “hurting,” she decides she doesn’t “hate him at all.”

A young Black boy on a mule, later identified as Honor, approaches the house, and Golden comes out to see who it is. Golden is rude, but the boy (assuming that Golden is white) notes that he is slightly less rude than most white people. Honor informs Golden that Henry will be back soon, though Golden misses the pride in Honor’s voice when he mentions that Henry has entrusted him with some household tasks.

*Golden’s sense of entitlement to this small cottage speaks to the immense white privilege he has grown up with. The green dress now emerges as a symbol of Golden’s simultaneous desire to take some form of care and (because he is worried about ruining his clothes above all else) his limits as a caretaker.*



*Even though Golden’s closest relationship seems to be with True Belle, who never showed him anything but tenderness and care, his racist beliefs are so strong that he feels like he can dismiss True Belle as “nothing” simply because of the dark color of her skin.*



*The narrator has never been objective, but here, she loses herself entirely in the characters she is inventing, imagining things about Golden and then having an emotional response to her own conjectures. Golden’s focus on property above the wellbeing and survival of this Black woman echoes the discomfort that Alice Manfred was made to feel in department stores, when she was treated by white salespeople as if she was herself a commodity.*



*Though the narrator criticizes Golden for shaping his own story so actively, she is doing the same thing as she recounts her narrative to her readers. In Golden, the narrator embraces the contradiction she denies Joe and Violet, acknowledging both that Golden’s beliefs are inconsistent and that his feelings of abandonment and confusion are real and painful.*



*Here, it is likely that the narrator is reshaping Honor’s thoughts to make them more sympathetic to Golden. Honor seems touched to be trusted by the respected man, something that readers should keep in mind for later.*



Now, Golden changes into his nicest outfit. He marvels at the fact that he never missed having a father until he learned that he had one; he feels that this parent is like a phantom limb that he needs, even though it will cause him pain. For a moment, Golden decides he does not care about his father's race. All he hopes for, he thinks, is that "we will both be free, arm-tangled and whole."

The narrator now berates herself for not giving Golden enough credit—"I have been careless and stupid," she confesses, "and it infuriates me to discover (again) how unreliable I am." The narrator wonders what kind of private hurt Golden walks around with, and she hopes that he finds some measure of peace. Golden orders Honor to tend to the woman on the bed, and the boy does so. Golden realizes he is ready for the woman's "deer eyes" to open.

## CHAPTER 7

Thirteen years later, rumors about the woman on the bed—known as Wild to the people of Vienna—are still circulating. People believe she can curse babies, so pregnant girls are frightened of her. But grandfathers are also susceptible to Wild's haunting presence, caught off guard when she touches them or whispers in their ears while they work in the fields.

The man everyone calls Hunter's Hunter—Henry Lestory—thinks back on the first day he met Wild. After she awoke, she was gentle and laughing; for the few days she stayed at Hunter's house, she used to spend much of her time with Golden Gray. And though Wild is mostly an urban legend now, Hunter knows she is real.

When Golden arrives at the small cottage in Vienna, Hunter is anxious to have a white man in his house; suddenly, the house no longer feels like it belongs to him. Hunter notices that Golden has drunk his liquor, and he is shocked by this white man's familiarity. Hunter asks if they know each other, and Golden replies, "no, Daddy. We don't." Hunter assures his son that he never knew he existed before this moment, as Vera Louise never told him (because she wanted Golden to think he was white).

*Golden's feelings of abandonment seem to confirm all the narrator's worst suspicions about the cyclical nature of relationships—he felt abandoned, and that abandonment transferred to the children who came into contact with him (both Joe and Violet, in different ways). And more contradictions emerge: even as Golden's racism is anything but freeing, he hopes that bonding with his father will allow them both to feel newly "free."*



*Here, the narrator's doubts about her invented stories now take on new stakes, as she becomes frustrated with herself for failing to understand the past and present from the comfort of her room. For the first time, it seems that the narrator's desire to know everything is self-protective; if she is "careless and stupid," unable to "rely" on her own conjectured stories, what can the narrator ever truly rely on for stability and safety?*



*The novel has already shown that gossip can make someone a feared legend in a neighborhood (like how Violet becomes known as "Violent" to the people she lives near). Here, that kind of gossip extends to Vienna, too, where Wild provokes some rural counterparts to the urban legends that surround Violet.*



*This passage makes it clear that the woman known as Wild is in fact the woman Golden found by the side of the road. Again, the characters in the novel are all seen to contain contradictions, as Wild is at once frightening and gentle, mysterious and quick to laugh.*



*Golden frames his entitlement to Henry's house and alcohol as a result of their familial relationship, but Henry does not trust this. Instead, Henry feels that Golden is motivated by a racialized arrogance, feeling that he deserves not only Henry's material possessions but his attention and paternal care.*





Shortly after this exchange, Wild goes into labor. As Wild struggles through a difficult birth, Golden explains how True Belle helped him find Hunter, and he chastises Hunter for not being more involved in his life. Hunter will have none of it; he snaps at Golden that he needs to choose whether to deride his Black parentage or accept it, asserting that “a son ain’t what a woman say. A son is what a man do.” Hunter knows that no matter what Golden says, the main reason he has come is to “see how black” his father really is.

First, Golden considers shooting and killing Hunter. But something—the narrator suspects it was Wild—makes Golden change his mind. The narrator reflects that women often have that impact on men. She wonders if Joe could even find the walnut tree where he met Violet, or if it burned down. She thinks Victory, Joe’s closest companion in the world, might be able to find the spot where the tree was.

The narrator reflects again on the fires and violence that drove the relatively prosperous Black population out of Vienna. Hunter refused to leave, but Victory and Joe decided to seek work elsewhere. Before they could leave, though, Joe wanted to find Wild—the woman Hunter had hinted to him was his mother. Joe spent much of his childhood looking for this woman, the source of so much shame and anger. Sometimes Wild was in the woods, sometimes in the sugar cane, but her favorite spot was a hibiscus patch by the river.

The first time Joe ever tried to contact Wild, he went to the hibiscus patch and called out to her. He heard a sound in the flowers and smelled something (what he thought was a mix of honey and excrement), but Wild never responded. When he returned to this hibiscus patch, after the fires, Joe could not be sure if Wild was dead or alive. He called out for her—“you my mother?”—but she never responded, not even to deny it. Though Victory tried to comfort him, Joe could not quite make peace with this mother who was “everywhere and nowhere.”

Now, on a winter day in New York, Joe is thinking about all of this as he tries to track down Dorcas. He recalls Hunter’s words about Wild: “she is not prey.” The gun is in Joe’s pocket—he is “hunting,” and so a gun feels like “a natural companion”—and he is sweating, despite the fact that it is cold outside.

*The fact that Wild is giving birth as Golden reveals the circumstances of his own parentage to Henry implicitly links Wild’s baby (whose identity will be revealed later) with Golden’s own sense of parental abandonment. Henry refuses to accept Golden’s racist mistreatment, insisting that Golden cannot let biology (either race or parentage) completely dictate the way he behaves in the world.*



*The narrator is now crossing many different strands of her story, reflecting both the complex structural nature of jazz music and the confusion between past and present, childhood and adulthood, that many of the characters struggle with. The story has earlier shown love and desire as disruptive forces, but in this moment, they starts to appear as productive emotions, making those who feel it (i.e., Golden) change for the better.*



*Hunter’s refusal to bend to Golden’s presumptuous, racialized behavior now links to his refusal to bend to the white violence that afflicts Vienna. Wild’s life, spent hidden in the woods, helps explain Joe’s eagerness to learn about hunting and tracking, trying to find living things in nature—whether it is animals or his missing mother—who would ideally avoid detection.*



*The phrase “everywhere and nowhere” suggests that Joe’s sense of abandonment—at having a mother who is always “nowhere”—haunts him “everywhere” he goes, an omnipresent, shaping force in his life. Joe’s description of Wild’s scent echoes this contradictory set of feelings, a token of the horror and pleasure he feels at being so close to this possible mother.*



*Just as the narrator sometimes mixes up the past and present, many of the wires in Joe’s brain seem to have gotten crossed. But despite Hunter’s best efforts to help Joe separate his desire to connect with his mother (and later, Dorcas) from his desire to “hunt” them, Joe cannot help but confuse the impulse to track these women with his instinct to “prey” on them.*



Joe gets on the subway. He sees three young women dressed up, flashing a “power” that Joe thinks these women will later exchange “for the right to be overcome, penetrated.” Joe thinks back to the last time he tried to find Wild, after he was married. The story slips into Joe’s perspective, and he wonders why Dorcas prefers the young “rooster” of a man she has started going out with.

Joe’s thoughts move back and forth in time. One moment, he imagines Dorcas forgiving him, promising him exclusivity and tenderness. The next moment, he recalls the day when he finally found the cave where Wild lived. There was a **green dress** there, a doll, and some beautiful linens and silver objects. But Wild herself was nowhere to be found.

*On the one hand, Morrison’s work is often interested in the true agency women have in romantic relationships. On the other hand, Joe’s attribution of “power” to these young women reflects his unwillingness to see their vulnerability, which perhaps links to his refusal to take responsibility for the murder he is about to commit.*



*Again, Joe’s desire to reconnect with Dorcas is clearly an extension of his desire to find the mother he never had. The fact that Wild held onto the green dress shows how much she valued Golden’s brief act of care—and suggests how devastating it is that Joe never received similar care from Wild herself.*



## CHAPTER 8

Dorcas has arrived at an “adult party,” and she is thrilled to be in a place where “no dancing brothers” are anywhere. Dorcas feels excited and alert, dancing closely with her new lover Acton. Their bodies move perfectly in sync, and though Dorcas has to chase this man—buying him presents instead of having presents bought for her—she feels she has won the ultimate prize. After all, this boy is young and “selective,” and Dorcas has never been so happy.

*Dorcas treats Acton with much of the same devotion Joe shows her, though neither of these loves are reciprocated. It is telling, though, that Dorcas is happier chasing after someone disinterested than she is in the calm of her relationship with Joe. This is perhaps a testament to the way in which she repeats the feeling of abandonment from her youth even as she tries to distance herself from it. Dorcas’s mention of the “dancing brothers” shows that their rejection months ago still stings her, shaping her actions even to this day.*



Dorcas starts to narrate her own story. A few days ago, she had asked Joe to leave her alone, telling him she was “sick” of him in what became an awful fight. Now, she knows he is coming for her; he might even arrive soon to this party, where she is with Acton and her best friend Felice. Dorcas is proud that Acton judges her when she wears glasses or goes back for seconds, and she likes that he is cold to her in public. Joe’s acceptance of Dorcas used to frustrate her.

*The fact that Dorcas begins narrating her own story here, much like the moments in which Joe or Violet have taken hold of the story, act as solos—much like the ones a saxophonist or piano player might take in a jazz band.*



To Dorcas, the party feels like “war”; nothing that happens after will feel as real. Suddenly, without realizing what is happening, Dorcas notices that Joe has arrived and that he seems to be crying. Dorcas feels like she is falling. Acton seems annoyed, and Felice is begging Dorcas to explain what happened, what Joe did. Dorcas feels herself drifting off into sleep. The music sounds extra loud. “Listen,” Dorcas instructs. “I don’t know who is that woman singing but I know the words by heart.”

*Having been shaped, early on, by the almost war-like violence of the East St. Louis Massacre, Dorcas does not intuitively know how to seek peace. The fact that she dies because of her craving for romantic “war” thus suggests that history is doomed to repeat itself, as she chases the very pain that marked her childhood. It is only fitting, then, that she dies while listening to a record—the pre-taped music will never change, so even if Dorcas doesn’t recognize the singer, she feels she already knows the words of the song “by heart.”*



## CHAPTER 9

The narrator observes that it is “sweetheart weather” in New York City, warm and comfortable. Everyone is outside, preening and flirting; the cars have stopped honking, not wanting to spoil the perfect day. A confident brass band is playing, with clarinets that sound almost “holy.” Even Violet, who normally covers herself with coats because she is embarrassed by her thin body, has shed her layers today. But Joe is still crying, even through the music.

Violet has recently returned the picture of Dorcas to Alice Manfred, but that does not mean she has stopped thinking about Dorcas herself. So when Felice climbs Violet’s stairs, carrying a **record** under her arm and dressed so similarly to her murdered friend, Violet almost imagines that it is Dorcas in the flesh. The narrator confesses that for reasons she cannot quite explain, Felice always makes us nervous.

Felice now tells her story. She lived with her grandmother while her parents worked in Tuxedo, New York; they would come to visit once every three weeks. Felice’s father was an avid reader of Black newspapers, and from him Felice learned how frequently police killed Black people with impunity. In her visits to “the City,” Felice’s mother always had to run errands for her bosses in Tuxedo, even though it was her day off.

Felice admits that her grandmother was constantly critical of Dorcas. Dorcas loved to gossip about who was pretty and who wasn’t, and she would sometimes get into fights with the other girls at school. But Felice felt that life with Dorcas was always more fun—until she started seeing Joe.

At first, Felice thinks Dorcas is seeing Joe for the presents and keeping it secret because she is embarrassed. But even though Joe is old, Felice has to admit that he is good-looking. Felice reflects that Dorcas is not pretty, though “she had all the ingredients of pretty.” And though Dorcas is charming, boys at school never seem interested in her. Felice thinks this is because there is something pushy about Dorcas. The reason Dorcas likes Joe, Felice decides, is because he is married and it feels illicit.

*The novel began in winter, and now spring is turning into summer, perfect for romance and flirting—though Joe and Violet still seem removed from the city’s infectious weather. For the first time, the narrator acknowledges the full emotional power of the “holy”-seeming brass band, jazz music, even if Joe struggles to let these feelings seep in.*



*At last, Felice’s arrival on the scene signals that this second “scandalizing threesome” (which the narrator warned would lead to a second murder) has formed. If the narrator is right, it is fitting that Felice arrives with a record under her arm, a symbol of unbreakable destiny. But the narrator has to admit that Felice makes her nervous as a storyteller, the first hint that this trio’s relationship might not turn out like she predicts.*



*Felice gets her solo now, just like Joe, Violet, and Dorcas before her. Though Felice’s story is separate from the web of the rest of the characters’ lives, her family’s life, too, has been shaped by the rampant anti-Blackness in America.*



*Unlike the narrator, who tries to flatten people into archetypes and stories into inevitabilities, Felice is capable of recognizing Dorcas’s flaws even as she feels deeply affectionate towards (and admiring of) her bolder, more gossipy friend.*



*Felice understands that there is something almost desperate in the way Dorcas approaches Joe, as if she is dating him more for assurance about her own worth than she is for reasons of attraction or comfort. After all, if Dorcas views going to parties as “war,” what more thrilling relationship could she find than an illicit one?*



When she was a child, Felice went with her mother to Tiffany's, as part of one her mother's errands for work. Felice and her mother tried to try on some of the rings, but the salespeople were rude and suspicious of them. After Felice got home, her mother gave her an opal ring that she claimed her boss had given to her—though Felice knew it was stolen.

*Earlier, Alice Manfred has described one way that racism shows up in department store shopping, as the clerks touch her as if she is merchandise or refuse to call her (as would be respectful) by her last name. Now, the suspicion that Felice and her mother face from the salesclerks in Tiffany's signals yet another way that anti-Blackness is woven into the daily fabric of life for Felice and her community.*



When Dorcas started dating Acton, she borrowed that ring. Dorcas used to spend hours trying to find presents for Acton; Felice reflects that Dorcas treated Acton like Joe treated her, and Acton took Dorcas for granted like Dorcas took Joe for granted. Felice's grandmother says Dorcas "brought it on herself."

*Felice's reflections here make Dorcas's death seem cyclical and inevitable in every way. Dorcas is transferring the behavior she has learned from Joe to Acton, a repetition that Felice's grandmother sees as Dorcas bringing her own murder "on herself." And in borrowing the ring Felice's mother stole, Dorcas almost wears the pain of that moment (with the suspicious salesclerk) on her body, as if marking herself for doom.*



After Dorcas's death, Felice goes to Joe's house to get her ring back. Felice wants to show the ring to her family again; her mother is retired now, while her father has a job he likes on the Pullman, where he can read about the Black baseball leagues. But Felice, who didn't go to Dorcas's funeral, has another reason for visiting Joe. She has heard he still cries about Dorcas all the time, and she wants to tell him that Dorcas is not worth all of these tears.

*In contrast to the unfortunate destiny that the narrator and many others have attributed to Dorcas's life, Felice's family seems to have a more hopeful story: her parents leave their oppressive, inequitable jobs for retirement or more fulfilling work. Perhaps, then, Felice's decision to help Joe end his crying jag is motivated by a desire to extend some of that same hopefulness to the Trace family.*



When Felice arrives, the first thing Violet says to her is that Dorcas "was ugly. Outside and in." Felice is taken aback by this, but she respects Violet's honesty. Felice thinks Violet is just jealous, but she also notices that Violet is very pretty. And when Felice meets Joe, she is surprised to discover that he "likes women"—not just to flirt with, but as people to talk to. Felice thinks Joe seems to especially like his wife.

*While the narrator is determined to make people match up with her preconceptions of them, Felice allows herself to be surprised not only by Joe and Violet as individuals but by the intimacy they seem to have settled in with each other. Though this bond is a new development within the context of the novel, it is entirely possible that this closeness has existed beyond this moment—and the narrator was just too wrapped up in her own imagination to see it.*



After that first visit, Violet invites Felice back for dinner, and Felice goes; she wants to see Joe and hear Violet talk. Violet tells Felice that she feels like she messed up her life, spending too much time wanting to be younger and lighter-skinned and not enough time being "the woman my mother didn't stay around long enough to see." Violet even tells Felice about Golden Gray.

*Violet's growth over the course of the story is evident here. Early on, she was determined to change herself, obsessing over Dorcas and her past decisions and forcing herself to eat malteds to change the shape of her body. Now, Violet is more focused on the future, trying to move forward from both her personal history and some of her familial trauma.*



Sometimes, Joe struggles to be around Felice, and Violet snaps to Felice that “your ugly little friend hurt him and you remind him of her.” But Felice is firm that she is different from Dorcas. She resents Dorcas for letting herself die so easily, and as Felice confesses this, she starts to cry. Joe asks her if this is the first time she has ever cried over her friend, and Felice realizes that it is.

*This scene reveals two important details. First, while the narrator believes that the Felice-Joe-Violet trio merely repeats the Dorcas-Joe-Violet trio, Felice is firm that this could not be further the case; she is different, and she wants to build a different relationship with the Trace couple. And second, Joe helps Felice process Dorcas’s death even as Felice does the same for Joe, a more reciprocal relationship than almost any the novel has previously shown.*



Even after Felice learns that her mother’s ring was buried with Dorcas instead of left with Joe and Violet, she returns to the Trace household. She looks forward to the way Violet talks about herself; in her mouth, the word “me” is not “somebody she had put together for show” but rather “somebody she favored and could count on.”

*Just a few months ago, Violet was dissociating into two versions of herself, pitting her regretful, rational side against the person she called “that Violet.” But now, Felice sees that Violet is confident in the word “me,” and therefore in her sense of herself; rather than telegraphing some image to the world, Violet is proud of all of the facets and contradictions of her personality.*



One visit, Joe sits next to Felice on the sofa, which makes Felice nervous at first. Joe argues that Dorcas was kinder than Felice gives her credit for, more “soft.” Felice believes that Dorcas used people, but Joe confesses that he probably wanted to be used. Felice then tells Joe that Dorcas’s last words were about him, which moves Joe greatly.

*Even as Felice’s narrative emphasizes the surprising intimacy between Violet and Joe, this exchange makes it clear that Joe retains a great deal of feeling for Dorcas. And there are sides of Dorcas, it seems, that readers will never know—yet one more testament to the idea, so terrifying to the narrator, that everyone is ultimately unknowable to outsiders.*



At the end of the evening, after Violet has curled a last-minute client’s hair, Felice puts on a **record** and the Traces start to dance with each other. It’s a little funny to Felice, but she also feels touched, as if she is witnessing a private moment. When the couple invites Felice to dance, she doesn’t join in, even though she wants to. As she leaves, Violet tells her to come back soon, and Joe remarks that the house needs **birds**.

*Here, two of the novel’s key symbols invert their meaning. Records originally represented the idea of inevitable fate. But now, as Joe and Violet dance in this intimate, awkward way to a record, it is clear that nothing is pre-ordained, as even the most broken relationships can heal and get stronger. Moreover, the birds, which once stood in for the isolation Joe and Violet felt from each other, now come to represent their newfound closeness.*



Felice decides to tell her mother the truth about what happened to the ring. She reflects that she loves the ring not because of the fancy opal, but because it represents a rare moment when her mother “broke the rules.” Felice thinks back to the party, and to the fact that she didn’t have a boy of her own there; she was just accompanying Dorcas and Acton. It’s warm outside, and Violet’s catfish is good, though too spicy. Felice needs to drink water to “ease the pain.”

*In “breaking the rules” to take the ring, Felice’s mother simultaneously flouts the white supremacy baked into her everyday life and proves that she is capable of bucking expectations, of improvising. And Felice, working through the grief of Dorcas’s death and the strangeness of this new friendship with Violet and Joe, seems to feel a similar commitment to the future—to letting herself surprise herself, to doing what she needs to do to “ease the pain.”*





## CHAPTER 10

The narrator wonders if she has a “sweettooth” for pain, a kind of desire for hurt and blood. The narrator thinks she has spent too much time inside, and she resents the fact that even after all this time observing the other people in “the City,” she still doesn’t quite understand them. And somehow, even though she has kept quiet and just looked out the window, everyone else seems to know all about the narrator.

After all, the narrator was convinced that Joe or Violet would kill each other, “that the past was an abused **record** with no choice but to repeat itself.” But while the narrator was making predictions, the Trace couple was “busy being original—complicated, changeable, human.”

When the narrator sees Joe, Violet, and Felice together, they look just like the love triangle the narrator pictured with Dorcas. But this whole time, the narrator realizes, Joe has been looking for Wild more than for that young girl. Now, the narrator imagines herself into Wild’s cave, with the **green dress**. She likes the idea of finding peace with this woman who “scared everybody.” The narrator feels that Wild might “see” her in a way no one else does.

Alice moves back to Massachusetts. Felice still buys **records** and brings them to Joe and Violet, walking slowly but thinking quickly. Joe gets an all-night job at a speakeasy, and Violet cooks him a big breakfast every morning when he returns. After Violet’s appointments, Joe meets her at the drug store, where they split a malted. Sometimes, the couple will walk around and rest on stoops or take the train all the way down to 42nd street.

Eventually, Violet and Joe buy another **bird**, and though it seems sick at first, it cheers up once they bring it to the roof to hear music. They look forward to buying themselves a satin blanket, and having that soft fabric cool them after they have sex. Sometimes, Joe thinks back to a day in Vesper County, when he came home to find Violet asleep and tender and childlike.

*Now, forced to face the evidence of Joe and Violet’s reconciliation instead of the further collapse she predicted, the narrator must admit that the gossip she so eagerly trafficked in revealed more about herself than it did about the people she watched. The lyrical, fragmentary tone of this passage shows just how much the novel has formally aligned with its improvisational, jazz-like content.*



*In this essential line, the narrator admits that life is not pre-taped like the music on an “abused record”; the past, in other words, does not dictate the future. Instead, each day is just as changeable as jazz music, which Morrison herself describes as being defined by “improvisation, originality, change.” And so Joe and Violet can defeat the odds, returning to each other and bringing Alice and Felice into their fold, at last finding in middle age the intimacy they so badly wanted in their youth.*



*Joe and Violet have both, over the course of the story, recognized how their experiences in childhood (and specifically their longing for absent or dead parents) impacts and confuses their adult romantic desires. But now, the narrator realizes that she, too, is suffering from confusion—that the hunger for Wild’s care that she projected onto Joe is in fact a hunger she shares.*



*If the narrative began with intrigue and gossip, it concludes with normalcy and routine. The reciprocity in Joe and Violet’s relationship is clear in the way they share a malted (as Violet once imagined Joe did with Dorcas) and get each other treats, a shift from the one-sided relationships seen earlier in the novel.*



*That Joe and Violet now purchase another bird symbolizes their newly reciprocal love; the fact that the bird loves listening to jazz is a reminder that unpredictability and improvisation are the very building blocks of natural life. The memory Joe has of seeing Violet vulnerable and childlike suggests that the couple is now able to heal each other’s youthful pain, repairing the past instead of letting themselves be dictated by it.*



The narrator feels that Violet and Joe and their story are real to her, almost omnipresent. She envies their public love and reflects that she has only ever loved in secret. The narrator wants to find something like what Violet and Joe have—their ability to share snippets from their past with each other, to say to each other “make me, remake me. You are free to do it and I am free to let you because look, look. Look where your hands are. Now.”

*The narrator now relinquishes the gossip that has sustained her—and the novel itself—for so many pages. Instead, she gives herself over to the rhythmic beauty of jazz, with its promise of some kind of freedom and its sensuality, its ability to “make” and “remake” itself all the time.*





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